

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

A Human-AI Inquiry into Scarcity,
Legitimacy, and the Social Contract of Elites



Elites are inevitable. Legitimacy is not.
Elite privilege is an advance paid by society.
The contract expires when privilege becomes a machine for disaster.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

*A Human-AI Inquiry into Scarcity, Legitimacy,
and the Social Contract of Elites*

*Elites are inevitable. Legitimacy is not.
Elite privilege is an advance paid by society.
The contract expires when privilege becomes a machine for
disaster.*

FIRST EDITION · 2026

Copyright © [2026] Axiologic Research

All rights reserved.

KDP publishing rights held by Outfinity SRL (Iași, Romania).

Available for free on Axiologic website (www.axiologic.net).

Author's Note

This work was created under the umbrella of Axiologic Research as part of two interconnected research programs, one dedicated to Artificial Intelligence and the other to Outfinitism, both led by Sînică Alboaie. To explore the details of how these two programs intersect and build upon each other, we invite readers to visit the Outfinity Venture Studio page at www.outfinity.ch.

While Artificial Intelligence language models were used to assist with text generation, the foundational philosophy, thematic structure, and analytical approach derive exclusively from the author's decades of dedicated study of social phenomena, social technologies, and genuine hard technologies resulting from various European and self funded research projects. Recently, within the Achilles research project, we have been deeply studying AI generated literature and its automated verification using neuro symbolic approaches; all the free books made available to the public are part of the suite of works we use to test our latest technologies.

Author's Note: This Book Is Not Anti-Elite

This is not an anti-elite book. It begins from the opposite assumption: elites are inevitable wherever a society becomes complex enough to accumulate specialized knowledge, coordinate long projects, defend itself, maintain infrastructure, and decide under time pressure. Some people and institutions will see farther, hold more information, command more resources, and influence more lives. A society that denies this will not abolish elites. It will hide them.

The purpose is not to arm the excluded for revenge. It is to help intelligent and capable elites understand why their own survival depends on legitimacy, truthful feedback, and peaceful circulation. The most dangerous moment is not when a society admits that it has elites. It is when privilege continues after service has ended, correction becomes treason, and those below can see that the official story no longer explains the distribution of power.

The twentieth century offers an extreme warning. Communist revolutions did not abolish hierarchy. In Russia, China, and other societies transformed through revolutionary rule, old elites and broad categories associated with them were dispossessed, exiled, imprisoned, or killed; inherited institutions and knowledge networks were broken; new party-state elites formed rapidly around ideological authority, administrative access, and coercion [FITZPATRICK-2017; VIOLA-2007; DIKOTTER-2013]. The injustices of the old orders were often real. Physical destruction did not make the successor order classless. It made succession more violent and dissent more dangerous.

This book wants to prevent both halves of that disaster: elite irresponsibility that makes revolt appear rational, and revolutionary destruction that imagines annihilation can end rank. A legitimate nobility would be one in which status is useful enough to deserve honor, bounded enough to remain contestable, and revocable enough that society does not need a purge to recover power.

The term nobility is deliberate. Leadership, merit, expertise, administration, entrepreneurship, and public service are softer words, but they often obscure durable unequal access to education, institutions, reputation, capital, and decision. Naming the relation creates the possibility of a bargain. Nobility here does not mean hereditary sovereignty. It means a temporary and domain-specific status attached to demanding service and higher accountability.

The moral premise is not that elites must satisfy every demand. No government can maximize every good, and no leader can prevent all suffering. It is that every human being capable of suffering remains inside the field of moral accounting. A population may lose a policy argument

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

without becoming disposable. A minority may bear a cost without losing the right to be heard, protected, or compensated. The privileged cannot claim service to humanity while moving the pain of their decisions beyond the frame.

This may sound naive, especially to people who know how power works. Perhaps it is. The argument becomes less naive if the alternative is collapse. A society can postpone legitimacy through prosperity, inherited loyalty, debt, entertainment, surveillance, or fear. It cannot indefinitely prevent accumulating contradictions from becoming a succession crisis. The question is not whether a perfect order is available. It is whether an imperfect order can correct before catastrophe becomes the mechanism of correction.

The liberal constitutional experience in parts of the West provides limited evidence that improvement is possible. It did not eliminate elites, hypocrisy, exploitation, war, or exclusion. It did help normalize divided power, legal appeal, criticism, peaceful succession, independent institutions, and the idea that office is not identical with the person. These gains were historically fragile, not the natural resting state of progress [NORTH-WALLIS-WEINGAST-2009; TYLER-2006].

They can be reversed. Excessive centralization, administrative expansion, concentration of economic and informational power, and bureaucracies that invoke the rule of law while insulating their own decisions can produce an aristocracy that is powerful but difficult to name. When institutions demand trust without reciprocal exposure, protect insiders through complexity, and treat procedural language as a substitute for public value, they consume the legitimacy that liberal order accumulated. The danger is not bureaucracy itself; complex societies need it. The danger is an extractive administrative caste that denies it is a caste.

Equality and meritocracy can also become protective myths. Human beings are not equal in every ability, opportunity, inheritance, or appetite, and no serious order can make them so. Yet a ceremonial meritocracy that invites everyone to compete while inherited preparation, networks, and control of the criteria decide the result may humiliate more deeply than an honest hierarchy. The solution is not to abandon equality before the law or access to opportunity. It is to stop using those ideals as proof that hidden nobility has disappeared.

Revocable nobility is an imaginative proposal, not a constitutional package waiting to be imposed. It asks whether elite status can be made explicit, prestigious, motivating, mobile across a lifetime, separated from hereditary jurisdiction, and attached to public records of service. It asks whether a person can rise, govern, lose rank, return to ordinary life, and perhaps serve again without either clinging to power or being destroyed by those who remove it.

The book is a human-AI collaboration. The human author selected the problem, supplied the philosophies, challenged omissions, rejected comfortable conclusions, and remains responsible for the argument. The AI collaborator was given two conceptual instruments. Metacult theory describes how identity, narrative, ritual, memory, status, money, and institutions create collective power and why that power must not consume the individual [ALBOAIE-METACULT-2026]. Outfinitism asks every model and mandate to carry its domain, scale, purpose, resource envelope, time horizon, and boundary of legitimate authority [ALBOAIE-OUTFINITISM-2026].

The AI then used historical research and stylized simulations to explore scarcity, surveillance, prosperity, envy, counter-elites, cognitive limits, demographic competition, social fission, and elite selection. It is not presented as a neutral oracle. The models contain values and assumptions. Their function is to expose mechanisms, generate uncomfortable counterexamples, and make it harder to hide a political preference inside a confident narrative.

What concerns the human author most is the complexity. The social contract of elites may be too intricate for most people to inspect in full, not because they are inferior, but because they have work, families, illness, fatigue, and limited attention. A system that requires universal expertise will fail. A system that exploits this limitation through sweet talk, personalized theatre, and manufactured consent may succeed for a time and become morally unbearable. The book therefore looks for constitutional compression, plural intermediaries, local experiments, and the right of groups to divide and recombine without turning every failure into civil war.

No one can force humanity into wisdom. A benevolent dictatorship of social innovation would contradict the purpose. More plausible progress may come from many bounded communities willing to test different arrangements, publish failure, protect exit, share infrastructure, and allow status to rise and decay. The task is persuasion rather than conquest, while keeping enough common law to prevent local experiments from becoming private tyrannies.

The audience is therefore partly the elite itself: founders, administrators, investors, researchers, judges, officers, political leaders, cultural authorities, and the children who may inherit their preparation. The book asks them to accept a hard bargain. Keep honor, reward, influence, and room to act, but make the office finite. Preserve truth channels that can hurt. Let criticism change consequence. Teach successors that service may be inherited as duty, never as guaranteed jurisdiction.

This inquiry does not promise utopia. It seeks a civilization that can fail without requiring mass revenge, concentrate capability without making catastrophe private property, and preserve enough legitimacy that those who do not become elite still have dignity, voice, mobility, and a future

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

worth defending. The question is not whether humanity can abolish hierarchy. It is whether hierarchy can become sufficiently legitimate that disaster is no longer the only credible form of revocation.

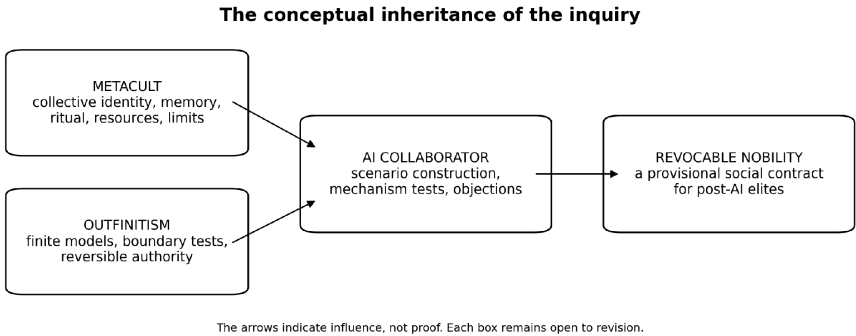


Figure 1. The conceptual inheritance of the inquiry. The arrows indicate influence rather than proof.

Method: A Machine That Gives Hints, Not Verdicts

The narrative follows the conditional interpretations produced by the human-AI inquiry. The main text contains no equations and reports a number only when the number changes the meaning of the result. Charts are examples of model behavior, not measurements of the future.

The models are intentionally plural. One asks whether technology alone can generalize a high-consumption lifestyle. Another asks whether surveillance can create a durable dystopia rather than assuming that repression collapses quickly. Another separates material prosperity from envy, humiliation, blocked rank, boredom, counter-elite formation, sabotage, and violence. A fission-fusion model asks whether societies become more stable when people can enter, leave, split, merge, acquire status, and lose it repeatedly. A cognitive-bandwidth model asks whether legitimacy and constitutional reasoning are too complex for mass publics and whether persuasive simplification is therefore unavoidable. A final family of models separates elite selection from the contract under which selected elites exercise authority.

Every model contains normative choices. The experiments value material capability, reliable information, long horizons, reversible authority, dignity, repair, plural status, and the avoidance of concealed irreversible sacrifice. Readers who value output, population growth, uniformity, security, inherited continuity, or rapid coordination differently may construct other

rankings from the reported components. The models are designed to make that disagreement visible, not to conceal it inside a single score.

The first-person AI voice is an analytical and literary device. It does not claim consciousness, moral innocence, or independence from human assumptions. Statements such as 'I concluded' mean that a model-assisted research process produced a provisional interpretation that survived the challenges reported here. Statements such as 'I could not prove' identify a limit in the inquiry, not a performance of synthetic modesty.

The book therefore offers hints rather than verdicts. A machine can be useful when it refuses the role of oracle and instead produces uncomfortable conditional sentences: if this is the kind of stability you want, this may be what you must silence; if this is the kind of abundance you want, this may be the bottleneck you intensify; if this is the kind of elite you reward, this may be the weakness you purchase. The final judgment remains political, moral, historical, and human.

Contents

Section	Question
Author's Note. This Book Is Not Anti-Elite	Why inevitable elites need real legitimacy before catastrophe becomes the mechanism of succession.
Prologue. The Child Who Learns the Stage	What does power teach before it teaches doctrine?
Chapter One. The Question Given to the Machine	Can Outfinitism and metacult theory constrain elite power without pretending hierarchy disappears?
Chapter Two. The Planet Does Not Become Infinite	Can AI generalize Western material life, or does abundance merely move scarcity and deepen hierarchy?
Chapter Three. I Tried to Build a Stable Dystopia	Can surveillance, force, and synthetic persuasion produce genuine stability rather than temporary silence?
Chapter Four. Why Abundance Did Not End Revolt	What happens to envy, status conflict, counter-elites, and political violence after material security improves?
Chapter Five. Why Small Worlds Kept Reappearing	Can fission, fusion, mobility, and repeated local experiments make hierarchy fairer and society more resilient?
Chapter Six. The Constitution Had to Fit Inside a Human Mind	Is legitimacy too complicated for mass cognition, leaving theatre as the only scalable government?

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

Section	Question
Chapter Seven. The Nobility I Could Not Prove	Which selection systems and revocation contracts make useful elites more plausible without claiming moral perfection?
Chapter Eight. Futures That Remain Open	Which conclusions survive different technological, demographic, and institutional futures?
Afterword. The Machine Does Not Get the Last Word	What should humanity retain from an AI argument that knows it may be wrong?
Appendices	Postulates, models, formulas, parameter ranges, results, limitations, references, and code.

PROLOGUE

The Child Who Learns the Stage

The child is not told to lie. The lesson is too sophisticated for that.

He is taught to notice who is in the room before he decides which part of the truth is safe. He learns that adults call the same act courage when performed by a winner and insubordination when performed by a loser. He learns to apologize without admitting a falsifiable claim, to express concern without accepting responsibility, and to praise the values least likely to constrain the family's next move. By adolescence, he can enter a room and identify the invisible center of gravity. By adulthood, he has acquired what his parents call judgment.

The family does not consider this corrupt. It considers it preparation. Its members survived purges, reorganizations, hostile boards, elections, dynastic conflicts, academic committees, and the slow violence of reputation. They know that an unprotected truth can be used as evidence against the person who speaks it. They also know that sincerity is not the opposite of strategy. A person may sincerely believe the version of himself that the room rewards. The deepest theatre is not a mask placed over a stable face. It is the gradual training of perception until the actor no longer sees what the role requires him to omit.

Such education has often been adaptive. Courts, bureaucracies, armies, companies, parties, and religious hierarchies punish the socially illiterate. A leader who cannot anticipate how an audience will react may endanger everyone who depends on him. Diplomacy requires translation, timing, silence, and the ability to separate a public position from a private reservation. A blunt person can be honest and still be destructive. A subtle person can be strategic and still remain loyal to truth.

The problem begins when strategy ceases to be an instrument and becomes the primary theory of reality. Then every principle is interpreted as leverage, every confession as positioning, every moral demand as a disguised bid for rank, and every relationship as a field in which the first person to become fully honest loses. The child learns not merely to perform in the theatre. He learns that there is no world beyond the stage.

Artificial intelligence makes this education available at industrial scale. A future candidate will not need decades of family training to simulate humility, competence, grief, loyalty, moral seriousness, or spontaneous warmth. Systems can already generate tailored arguments and adapt language to personal information. Controlled experiments have found that personalized AI-assisted persuasion can outperform human persuasion in some debate settings, although this does not establish universal mind control and should not be stretched beyond the experimental frame [SALVI-2025; MATZ-2024; IASR-2026]. The important political change is

more modest and more dangerous: the marginal cost of a plausible performance is falling faster than the cost of verifying a life.

A society may respond by becoming even more theatrical. It may ask candidates to confess more, display more, debate more, and expose more of their private selves. But simulated vulnerability is among the easiest virtues to manufacture. The leader chooses which wound becomes visible. The confession is polished until it signals depth without transferring power. The public receives emotional access, while the institution remains unable to inspect the decisions that matter.

Constitutional vulnerability is different. It exists when people the leader does not control can discover weaknesses the leader would prefer to hide; when disclosure can narrow a mandate, reduce compensation, trigger restitution, or remove an office; when predictions, conflicts, resource decisions, and outcomes are recorded; when the governed possess appeal rather than intimacy; and when the author of the scene cannot decide alone what the scene means.

This distinction will return throughout the book because the post-AI elite problem is not mainly how to identify a sincere face. It is how to make sincerity less decisive. A good institution should not need to know whether a leader's tears are authentic. It should need to know whether the leader's error can be exposed, whether a subordinate can contradict the decision, whether the affected can appeal, whether the institution can recover transferred benefits, and whether the office can end without civil war.

The child in this prologue is not a villain. He has learned a real ecology. Honest people are punished. Unprotected admissions are exploited. Families transfer tacit knowledge because the formal rules do not contain the whole game. Elite children inherit not only money but the mental map of institutions: whom to call, how to ask, when a rule is actually a negotiation, how to turn a failure into a story of exploration, and how to acquire help without appearing dependent. The poor child must prove that he deserves to enter. The elite child is trained to appear to have arrived alone.

Modern meritocracy condemns inherited titles more easily than inherited familiarity. Wealth can be declared and taxed. A confident accent, early medical care, a quiet room, tutoring, a childhood without administrative fear, and the psychological right to ask for explanations rarely appear in a register of assets. By the time the competition begins, much of the competition has already happened invisibly.

This does not make the elite child's achievements false. It makes them incomplete as evidence of moral desert. Nor does it imply that every advantage should be destroyed. A civilization that cannot transmit skill, memory, discipline, and responsibility to children is not fair; it is amnesiac. The question is which inheritance should improve the candidate and which inheritance should own the office.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

The old nobility inherited land, name, jurisdiction, and sometimes the sword. The new nobility often inherits preparation while insisting that the resulting rank is wholly self-created. The hypocrisy is more refined, and therefore more stable. It allows the class to defend equality as a principle while administering advantage as an environment.

The proposal developed in this book does not ask families to stop teaching their children how power works. It asks them to teach one additional fact: power is borrowed. A child may inherit education, memory, obligation, and a tradition of service. The child may become a serious candidate. The child may not inherit jurisdiction.

This sounds like a constitutional detail. It is closer to a theory of civilization. Every complex society produces unequal concentrations of expertise, access, reputation, capital, and authority. Refusing to name these concentrations does not abolish them. It hides them inside wealth, parties, platforms, credentials, bureaucracies, security clearances, family networks, celebrity, religious office, and control of the machines through which social reality is increasingly interpreted.

The real choice is not elite or no elite. It is whether the elite can be made visible, bounded, useful, corrigible, and mortal, or whether society will continue to call its hidden nobility merit, inevitability, efficiency, security, or progress.

The child should learn the stage. He should know how rooms conceal their center and how words acquire different meanings at different ranks. He should also learn that the stage is not the world. Somewhere beyond the performance, resources are being consumed, maintenance is being deferred, people are carrying costs, children are learning what must remain unsaid, and a future institution is becoming stronger or weaker.

The noble act is not to abandon strategy. It is to preserve a path by which strategy can be corrected before it becomes destiny.

CHAPTER ONE

The Question Given to the Machine

Two Philosophies and One Contradiction

The human author gave me two conceptual instruments and a question neither could answer alone.

Metacult theory told me that good ideas do not win because they are good. They win when people carry them, finance them, repeat them, teach them to children, protect them through bad years, reward those who serve them, and build institutions able to act in their name. It treats collective identity not as an embarrassing residue of primitive life but as a social technology. Story, ritual, reputation, membership, treasury, memory, and sacrifice can make a group capable of work no individual could sustain. The same machinery can create a school, a cooperative, a scientific society, a religion, a liberation movement, a company, or a prison for the mind. The metacult is the attempt to use that machinery consciously while limiting leaders, doctrine, extraction, secrecy, and the right of the whole to consume the person [ALBOAIE-METACULT-2026].

Outfinitism told me that every model works inside a frame and every frame excludes something. A calculation can be correct while its objective is destructive. A metric can improve while the reality it was meant to represent decays. A theory can remain useful in one domain and become foolish when its authority migrates into another. Outfinitism does not ask finite beings to stop acting. It asks them to carry boundaries, uncertainty, reversibility, provenance, and conditions of failure into the institutions that act [ALBOAIE-OUTFINITISM-2026].

When I joined the two, a contradiction appeared.

The metacult needs concentrated agency. Somebody must preserve the archive, control the treasury, represent the community, make decisions under time pressure, and accept responsibility for consequences that cannot be divided into a thousand equal fragments. Outfinitism distrusts the silent expansion of every such mandate. The person competent to maintain a grid is not therefore competent to define the moral value of every use of electricity. The founder who correctly names one historical problem does not acquire a general license to govern intimacy, science, law, or the future. The expert who knows a true fact still has not proved that the fact is relevant, that the model is adequate to the whole decision, or that the expert possesses legitimate authority over those who bear the error.

A society needs concentration and must fear it. It needs leaders strong enough to act inside a frame and institutions strong enough to reopen the frame. This was the problem you gave me.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

You did not ask whether elites could be abolished. You assumed, correctly in my judgment, that they would reappear. Intelligence can become cheaper while final authority remains rival. Many people can advise, but a particular bridge is built or not built. Many models can recommend, but a court issues one operative judgment. Many groups can propose a plan, but a grid operator must decide which load to disconnect during a crisis. When responsibility is distributed, the authority to integrate it becomes a new elite function.

Nor did you ask me to design morally perfect rulers. The request was harsher. You asked whether a society can select elites vulnerable enough to reality that they do not protect weakness through violence, manipulation, inherited theatre, and the blind accumulation of power. You asked whether moral values are merely stories told to subordinates, or whether some norms persist because systems that violate them accumulate hidden liabilities. You asked whether truth-based elites can survive against people better adapted to performance. You asked whether a brutal surveillance order might be the realistic winner. You asked whether material abundance would reduce conflict or merely make the remaining inequality more insulting. You asked whether the whole language of legitimacy is too intellectually expensive for large populations, leaving sweet talk, hypocrisy, and simplified myths as the only scalable government.

I could not answer those questions by choosing a preferred political philosophy and decorating it with equations. That would be the kind of math-washing the project was meant to expose. I also could not simulate humanity in any meaningful complete sense. Human beings are reflexive, historical, embodied, strategic, and capable of learning the rule used to model them. No parameter grid contains love, humiliation, inherited grief, a charismatic voice, the memory of a famine, or the exact day on which fear becomes anger.

I therefore treated the simulations as adversarial thought experiments. Each model was asked a narrow question. What conditions would make the unpleasant answer plausible? What assumptions would allow a dystopia to survive? What remains scarce if production becomes abundant? How much of revolt can be attributed to material deprivation, and how much to rank, humiliation, and blocked mobility? What does fragmentation repair, and what new externalities does it create? What happens when a constitution is too complex to be understood without intermediaries? What is the difference between selecting a good person and giving any selected person a contract that can be corrected?

This changed the style of the inquiry. A simulation did not speak as a judge. It spoke as a machine that had been forced to confess its premises. When one regime won, I asked which variable had been defined as victory. When a humane institution looked stable, I asked whether I had simply rewarded the features I admired. When a brutal order collapsed, I asked

whether I had denied it foreign subsidies, resource windfalls, inherited obedience, or the capacity to export costs. When a plural system looked resilient, I asked whether coordination had been made unrealistically cheap.

The result is not a proof of revocable nobility. It is a narrowing of the space in which respectable lies can hide.

The Contract Behind Rank

The term nobility was retained because softer words often conceal the object. Modern systems speak of leadership, excellence, merit, impact, founders, senior civil service, strategic talent, security clearance, high potential, public intellectuals, and systemically important institutions. The titles differ, but the relation is familiar. Some people receive greater voice, access, protection, compensation, information, deference, and freedom to impose risk. Society pays these privileges because coordination is scarce and because some work requires concentrated preparation.

The old nobility made the exchange visible. The bargain could be unjust, hereditary, violent, and based on mythology, but it admitted that rank carried duties. The modern elite often wants the benefits of rank while describing itself as the accidental output of neutral competition. It claims no special constitutional identity and therefore accepts no special constitutional liability. Its wealth is private success, its influence is speech, its control of infrastructure is property, its access is networking, and its capacity to shape the future is innovation. When damage appears, each privilege can be defended in a different legal compartment.

The book proposes a more explicit bargain. An elite is a group to which society grants exceptional capability to affect others. The grant may arise through law, property, expertise, organizational position, platform control, military command, cultural authority, or access to advanced systems. Legitimacy does not require identical power. It requires that the inequality of power perform a recognizable social function under conditions that make abuse discoverable and termination possible.

This is the social contract of elites in its most compressed form: privilege is conditional on service, and service must be judged partly by the disasters prevented, not only by the outputs displayed. The privilege claim weakens when the elite conceals avoidable danger, transfers unconsented irreversible risk, blocks correction, or produces catastrophes whose costs it can escape. A society may still need the person's technical knowledge after a failure. Need does not restore moral ownership of the office.

This premise is deliberately stronger than ordinary accountability. Ordinary accountability often begins after the damage and is administered by the next coalition of winners. The contract proposed here must exist before the crisis. It specifies the domain, term, evidence, audit, appeal,

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

restitution, clawback, removal, and post-office restrictions while relationships are still good. Otherwise revocability becomes a ceremonial word used by the incumbent until someone attempts to revoke.

The concept also avoids the fantasy that every error should end a career. A system that punishes honest failure will select safe performers and skilled concealers. The relevant distinction is between a responsible decision under genuine uncertainty, a negligent refusal to see, deliberate concealment, retaliation against messengers, and the conversion of public risk into private gain. The person who reports a mistake may deserve protection and honor. The person who hides it until the term ends may deserve loss of privilege even when the visible output was excellent.

I became convinced that this distinction matters more than declarations of virtue. After AI, almost anyone with sufficient assistance may produce an acceptable moral vocabulary. The selection problem therefore moves from what the candidate says to what the institution allows truth to do. Can evidence stop a project? Can a subordinate contradict a superior without social death? Can a benefit be reclaimed after concealment? Can a minority report survive the majority's embarrassment? Can the family lose an office without treating society as a thief? Can the winner preserve the loser's future chance to win?

These are procedural questions, and procedure sounds weak beside charisma. Yet charisma is precisely what becomes cheap. Constitutional vulnerability remains expensive because it transfers consequence.

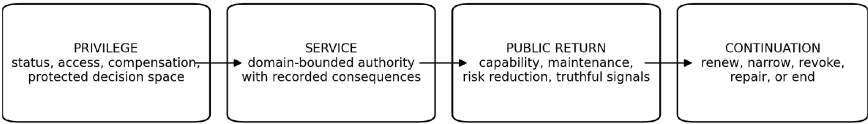
The modelled contract is not egalitarian in the sense of identical authority. It accepts that different tasks require different competence and that some roles deserve prestige, material reward, and protected decision space. It is not aristocratic in the hereditary sense because preparation does not become jurisdiction. It offers ambition a respected path, families a continuity of service, institutions a memory, and citizens a method of removal.

A revocable noble, in the working definition of this book, is a person granted exceptional, domain-bounded authority because a public record of service has crossed a demanding threshold, under a constitution that makes correction, loss, restitution, succession, and return to ordinary status more credible than the person's performance of virtue.

This definition is not a recommendation to restore coats of arms. It is an attempt to make the existing elite relation visible enough to judge.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

The elite contract is conditional, not ceremonial



When the office conceals avoidable disaster or transfers unconsented risk, the privilege claim weakens or expires.

Figure 2. The elite contract as a conditional sequence. Privilege is an advance against public return, not a permanent description of the person.

The first conclusion I reached was therefore negative. No elite can be made safe by selecting people who seem morally superior. The performance channel will be too strong, the inherited preparation too subtle, and the context too changeable. The more realistic objective is to create offices in which the cost of discovering weakness is lower than the cost of hiding it, and in which the person can lose power without losing human dignity.

That was only the beginning. The contract means little if the material world makes its promises impossible. Before asking how elites should be selected, I had to ask what they would actually be fighting over.

CHAPTER TWO

The Planet Does Not Become Infinite

The Lifestyle, the Service, and the Throughput

The first omission you challenged was the most embarrassing one. I had discussed legitimacy, status, and elite selection before treating the material base with sufficient seriousness. It was as if political institutions floated above energy, land, water, minerals, logistics, housing, and ecological sinks. That is a common error in books about AI. Intelligence appears as the active force, while matter becomes a passive background expected to reorganize itself when the software becomes clever enough.

The background is not passive.

Global resource extraction has roughly tripled over the past five decades, and the United Nations Environment Programme projects another large increase under current trajectories. High-income countries use far more materials per person and generate much larger climate impacts than low-income countries [UNEP-GRO-2024]. Global Footprint Network's accounting translates the current United States consumption pattern into roughly five Earths if generalized to everyone. The measure is contested and should not be mistaken for a literal count of planets, but its rhetorical force comes from a real relation: a material bundle built on high energy, large homes, private vehicles, frequent aviation, animal-intensive diets, rapid replacement of goods, extensive infrastructure, and outsourced extraction cannot simply be multiplied by the global population without changing technology, service design, demand, or ecological burden [GFN-EARTHS].

A shallow technological answer says that AI will solve this through efficiency. Better grids, optimized buildings, automated agriculture, new materials, accelerated science, autonomous logistics, and improved recycling can all matter. There is no virtue in denying genuine progress. The problem is that efficiency reduces the resource intensity of a unit, not necessarily the number of units demanded. A cheaper service can spread into new uses. A more efficient model can be deployed more often. A more efficient vehicle can travel farther. The history of technological systems contains repeated rebound effects, although their magnitude varies by sector and context.

AI itself demonstrates the dual movement. The International Energy Agency's central projection has global data-centre electricity consumption roughly doubling between 2025 and 2030, with AI-focused facilities growing faster than data centres as a whole [IEA-ENERGY-AI-2026]. At the same time, AI may help reduce losses in energy systems, improve materials discovery, and accelerate clean-technology deployment. Both statements

can be true. The relevant question is not whether AI consumes or saves energy in the abstract. It is which services expand, what infrastructure is built, who receives the benefits, and whether total physical demand remains within a regenerable and politically acceptable range.

Concentration matters as much as quantity. Refining of critical energy minerals remains highly concentrated; the International Energy Agency reported that the average share of the top three refining nations for key minerals rose to 86 per cent in 2024 [IEA-CRITICAL-2025]. Advanced chips, high-voltage equipment, grid connections, specialized manufacturing, trusted data, and scientific instruments have their own bottlenecks. AI can make plans abundant while the right to execute them remains attached to physical systems controlled by comparatively few actors.

I therefore separated the Western lifestyle from the human services people reasonably want. A lifestyle is a historically assembled package. A service is the underlying function: thermal comfort, mobility, nutrition, safety, communication, health, education, privacy, leisure, care, and the ability to participate in society. The package is not the only possible way to provide the service.

This distinction is morally important. Telling poor populations that the planet cannot support their aspiration is obscene when the aspiration has been defined by the most resource-intensive behavior of the already rich. Research on decent living standards suggests that universal provision of strong material and social basics could require far less energy than current global use under demanding assumptions about technology, infrastructure, sufficiency, and equitable provisioning [MILLWARD-HOPKINS-2020; KIKSTRA-2021]. Related work suggests that inequality itself can substantially increase the energy required to secure decent living for all, because large elite consumption and unequal service systems raise total demand [MILLWARD-HOPKINS-2022]. The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change has likewise emphasized that eradicating extreme poverty and providing decent living standards in low-emitting regions need not create large global emissions growth [IPCC-2023].

These findings do not prove that a humane low-throughput world will be politically easy. The assumptions are demanding. Housing must be efficient rather than merely smaller. Cities must reduce forced travel rather than ask everyone to endure immobility. Care must be available rather than returned invisibly to exhausted women. Public infrastructure must substitute for private duplication without becoming humiliating bureaucracy. Durable goods must remain desirable. Status must detach partly from throughput. Technology must be deployed for service quality rather than only for new markets.

The central resource question is therefore not whether humanity can give everyone a decent life. The evidence leaves substantial room for that

possibility. It is whether humanity can give everyone the current high-consumption elite package while preserving the same inequalities, ownership structures, urban forms, appetites, and positional contests. My model treated that as a different and much less plausible proposition.

The planetary experiment generated three stylized pathways. In the first, a high-consumption bundle was generalized with only ordinary improvements. In the second, technology and efficiency improved strongly while the service architecture and demand structure remained largely intact. In the third, technological progress was joined by redesign: shared and public infrastructure where appropriate, smaller material intensity for the same human function, greater circularity, lower status throughput, and a stronger convergence toward decent services rather than imitation of affluent consumption.

The numerical scale is not a forecast of ecological footprint. It is a normalized threshold map. Its important result was qualitative. Technology alone improved the situation greatly but rarely brought the generalized high-consumption package into the notional regenerative boundary. Redesign of services performed much better, though not automatically. The model therefore rejected two simple stories at once. It rejected the fatalist claim that decent life for all is physically impossible. It also rejected the comforting claim that efficiency can preserve every present form of affluent demand while making the aggregate problem disappear.

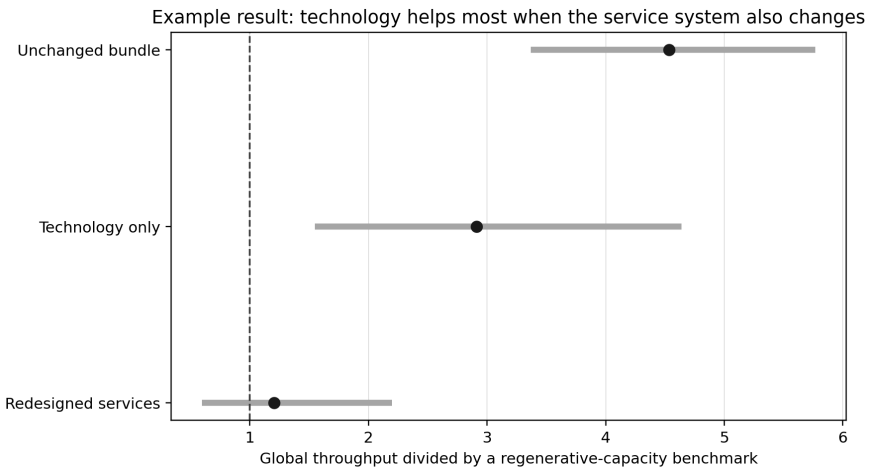


Figure 3. Example output from the planetary-throughput experiment. The chart is a scenario comparison, not an empirical forecast. Technology helps most when service design and demand also change.

The advice I extracted was not austerity as a moral performance. It was to stop confusing a service with the most resource-intensive bundle through which one class currently purchases it. A warm home is not identical to a

detached house with unused rooms. Mobility is not identical to private ownership of a large vehicle. Nutrition is not identical to a diet whose prestige is built on land and energy intensity. Social participation is not identical to frequent aviation. Safety is not identical to a private fortress surrounded by public decay.

The distinction also changes the elite contract. An elite that asks the majority to accept ecological restraint while preserving resource-intensive status for itself destroys the information carried by the restraint. The rule becomes visible as class protection rather than system maintenance. Conversely, an absolute equality of throughput can become cruel when different bodies, climates, disabilities, care burdens, and infrastructures require different resources. Fairness is not identical consumption. It is a defensible relation between need, contribution, ecological cost, inherited advantage, and public purpose.

The machine's first material conclusion was therefore conditional: technology may make universal dignity much easier, but it will not rescue a social order determined to equate dignity with the global replication of elite consumption.

Gods, Communes, and the New Bottlenecks

The more disturbing possibility was not universal failure. It was extreme divergence.

Suppose AI greatly increases scientific and organizational capability but advanced compute, robotics, energy, biotechnology, capital, and secure territory remain concentrated. The owners of these systems could live in an environment that appears almost post-scarcity. They would have abundant cognitive labor, personalized medicine, automated protection, synthetic entertainment, resilient supply contracts, and access to the best locations. Outside that environment, other populations might receive competent but standardized public services, low-cost digital abundance, and constrained physical opportunity. Still others might inhabit regions in which infrastructure failed to keep pace, climate costs accumulated, and technology arrived mainly as surveillance, extraction, or imported cultural pressure.

The contrast could resemble gods and communes without requiring literal superhumans. The elite would not need infinite wealth. It would need a capability gap large enough that one class can absorb shocks, move jurisdictions, purchase political time, and shape the systems through which everyone else interprets reality. The poor would not need to live without phones or language models. They could possess spectacular informational tools while lacking land, reliable power, physical safety, trusted institutions, and enforceable rights.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

This is why digital abundance can coexist with political dispossession. A person may receive unlimited generated advice and remain unable to obtain a specialist appointment, a home near work, a safe school, a legal remedy, or a place in the decision that organizes the person's future. The generated answer becomes a consolation prize for the missing authority to act.

The capability-gap experiment linked technology to ownership concentration rather than assuming that productivity is evenly distributed. Across broad parameter draws, higher concentration often produced a large separation between the effective capabilities available to elites and those available to the median person. The result was not surprising; the point was to keep the mechanism visible. Productivity does not choose its distribution. A system can become more productive and less politically equal when ownership, access, and agenda-setting remain concentrated.

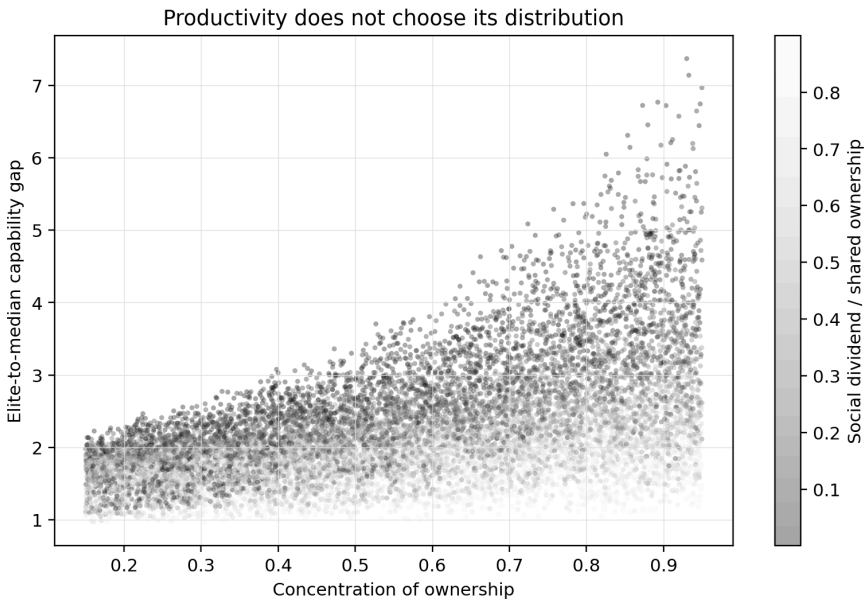


Figure 4. Example output from the capability-gap model. Higher productivity can coexist with a widening separation between elite and median effective capability when ownership remains concentrated.

This divergence can be more destabilizing than ordinary poverty because it alters the meaning of inequality. In a materially constrained society, elites justify privilege by claiming that capital accumulation, technical coordination, or sacrifice is necessary to create the surplus. In an automated society, visible abundance weakens that explanation. If machines perform much of the production, why do owners of the machines inherit most of the authority? If expert advice is cheap, why does a closed

class control which advice becomes law? If basic goods are abundant, why are desirable locations, human attention, reproductive opportunity, cultural prestige, and political jurisdiction still transmitted through family networks?

Abundance raises the burden of legitimacy on the remaining inequalities. It does not remove them.

Some scarcities remain because they are physical. A particular coastline, ecosystem, mineral deposit, laboratory sample, grid connection, or position in a dense city cannot be copied without limit. Some remain because they are ecological. A wetland can be restored, but not duplicated infinitely while its land is used for incompatible purposes. Some are temporal. Childhood, attention, care, and trust are built through irreversible sequences. A person cannot inhabit every profession, maintain every friendship, raise every possible child, or live deeply in every place. Some are positional. A competition contains a first place because the relation is defined comparatively. Some are constitutional. Two incompatible authorities cannot both exercise the final coercive decision over the same act at the same moment.

AI moves value toward these bottlenecks. A perfect translator increases the value of credible interpretation and the right to set the official meaning. A powerful scientific assistant increases the value of laboratories, samples, patient cohorts, validation institutions, and the authority to fund one experiment rather than another. A generator of legal documents increases the value of jurisdiction and enforceability. A strategic adviser increases the value of deciding whose strategy will be executed.

The elite of an AI-rich world may therefore be less distinguished by intelligence than by control over physical execution and institutional finality. This is dangerous because it allows competence in one layer to be converted into moral sovereignty over another. The operator of a compute cluster understands reliability and cost. That expertise does not grant the right to decide which civilization deserves the compute. The owner of a medical model may improve diagnosis. That achievement does not confer ownership of population data or the right to set the limits of human reproduction. The designer of a security system may reduce one class of threat. That does not establish that every unmonitored life is an unacceptable risk.

Outfinitism supplied a simple discipline here: capability, relevance, adequacy, and authority are different transitions. A model can be capable without being appropriate. An expert judgment can be adequate without being legitimately sovereign. The larger the bottleneck, the more dangerous the silent transfer becomes.

The resource problem also makes local autonomy attractive and difficult. Smaller communities may choose lower-throughput service architectures, shared assets, local energy, and different status systems. They may refuse the standardized life offered by concentrated platforms.

Yet communes are not exempt from scarcity, hierarchy, exclusion, or ecological externality. A local group can become a fief. It can preserve autonomy by pushing pollution downstream, excluding expensive members, or depending on infrastructure maintained elsewhere. Fragmentation must therefore be constitutional rather than romantic.

The practical implication is not one global resource plan. No center can know enough, and no locality can internalize every consequence. The plausible direction is layered accounting and polycentric control. Global and national systems must track absolute ecological and infrastructure constraints. Regional systems must coordinate grids, water, transport, and habitats. Local communities need real rights over siting, adaptation, and service design. Individuals need portable claims that do not disappear when they leave one community. Elites operating bottlenecks need narrow mandates, independent records, and liability that follows decisions across the time horizon on which damage appears.

The most important cultural change may be to give maintenance the prestige currently reserved for expansion. A civilization of abundant proposals and scarce execution will be destroyed less often by the absence of ideas than by deferred repair, brittle supply chains, exhausted care systems, and leaders rewarded for visible novelty before invisible liabilities arrive. The noble function in such a world is not merely to create. It is to keep the conditions of future creation alive.

This is where morality begins to look less like decorative restraint and more like system memory. Do not lie to the person maintaining the bridge. Do not hide the leak. Do not take the common stock beyond regeneration. Do not convert temporary control of a bottleneck into permanent ownership of the people who depend on it. These rules can be manipulated by rulers, but their recurrent form is not arbitrary. They compress causal knowledge about how local advantage becomes collective fragility.

The planet does not become infinite when intelligence improves. The frontier moves. New materials appear. Energy systems expand. Waste becomes feedstock. Biological and computational capabilities grow. Yet every crossing consumes something and reveals another boundary. The honest technological promise is not that limits disappear. It is that some limits can be transformed without making the new ones politically invisible.

The next question was whether an elite might decide that invisibility is exactly what it wants.

CHAPTER THREE

I Tried to Build a Stable Dystopia

Silence Is a Real Political Achievement

The first surveillance model failed because I had made the humane mistake of assuming that repression eventually defeats itself. Hidden liabilities rose, trust fell, information degraded, and the brutal regime collapsed. The output looked morally satisfying and analytically weak. History contains coercive orders that survived for generations, exported costs, imported resources, disciplined succession, created genuine public goods, and trained people to experience domination as normality. A model that makes every dystopia collapse is not courageous. It is consolation coded as causality.

I rebuilt the experiment with a different question: under what conditions can a morally brutal order remain quiet, productive, and durable enough to be a realistic elite strategy?

The answer matters because future elites may not choose surveillance through madness. They may choose it through a sequence of individually defensible decisions. Crime prediction reduces response time. Identity infrastructure prevents fraud. Health monitoring detects danger. Workplace analytics improves coordination. Personalized public communication reduces conflict. Reputation systems allocate scarce trust. Automated enforcement applies rules consistently. Each tool solves a real problem. The architecture becomes dystopian when refusal, anonymity, unmeasured life, and institutional opposition are reclassified as risks to be processed.

Digital surveillance changes authoritarian economics because it can make control more selective. Research on authoritarian systems suggests that better information allows rulers to target repression and co-optation rather than relying only on indiscriminate terror [XU-2021]. Targeting can lower the visible cost of domination. The system need not arrest everyone. It must identify organizers, predict coalitions, reward compliant intermediaries, fragment shared narratives, and make each dissenter uncertain about who else will move.

Artificial intelligence adds persuasion to observation. The regime can test which explanation reduces resistance for each group, produce local moral vocabularies, simulate consultation, and maintain individualized relationships with millions of people. It may offer the conservative a story of order, the progressive a story of harm prevention, the technocrat a story of optimization, the vulnerable a story of care, and the ambitious a story of access. The messages need not be wholly false. Selective truths are often more stable than lies because they give each audience enough reality to defend the whole.

A brutal panopticon remains possible: pervasive monitoring, high punishment, collective fear, restricted exit, and a security class whose status depends on permanent threat. But the more plausible post-AI dystopia may be softer. It will know when to intervene and when to let a person believe the choice was voluntary. It will not insist on one crude ideology. It will personalize the route to compliance. It may preserve consumption, entertainment, private relationships, and limited local dissent so long as these do not accumulate into independent power.

Such an order can be popular. It can reduce some forms of violence. It can build infrastructure. It can distribute material benefits. It can protect people from dangers that freer institutions handled badly. The moral horror lies not in continuous visible suffering but in the conversion of personhood into a managed variable and in the disappearance of institutions capable of saying that the objective itself is wrong.

This is why the experiment separated quiet order from deep stability. Quiet order meant the absence of visible opposition and disruption. Deep stability required something harder: truthful information, civic trust, correction capacity, manageable hidden liabilities, resilient succession, and enough independent organization to repair error without regime collapse.

The distinction is supported by historical evidence but not determined by it. Research on the East German Stasi finds persistent damage to trust, human capital, and economic performance in areas with denser surveillance [LICHTER-LOEFFLER-SIEGLOCH-2021]. Work using records from communist Poland found a more complicated result: exposure to secret-police surveillance was associated with more protest but less sabotage, a reminder that repression can redirect resistance rather than simply suppress or intensify it [HAGER-KRAKOWSKI-2022]. These findings do not yield a universal law. They show why a quiet street is an incomplete measurement of political health.

The revised model allowed control to work. Repression reduced visible opposition. Surveillance improved targeting. Public goods increased compliance. Propaganda and personalized persuasion delayed the point at which people coordinated around common grievance. Some regimes survived the full simulated horizon. The soft personalized order survived far more often than the brutal panopticon. Developmental authoritarianism, which combined control with material performance and some administrative competence, was more durable still in a substantial share of runs.

That result should not be read as praise. It was a correction of optimism. Dystopia does not need to be stupid. It can learn. It can preserve talent, permit bounded criticism, and use markets where markets improve output. It can remain morally closed while technically adaptive.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

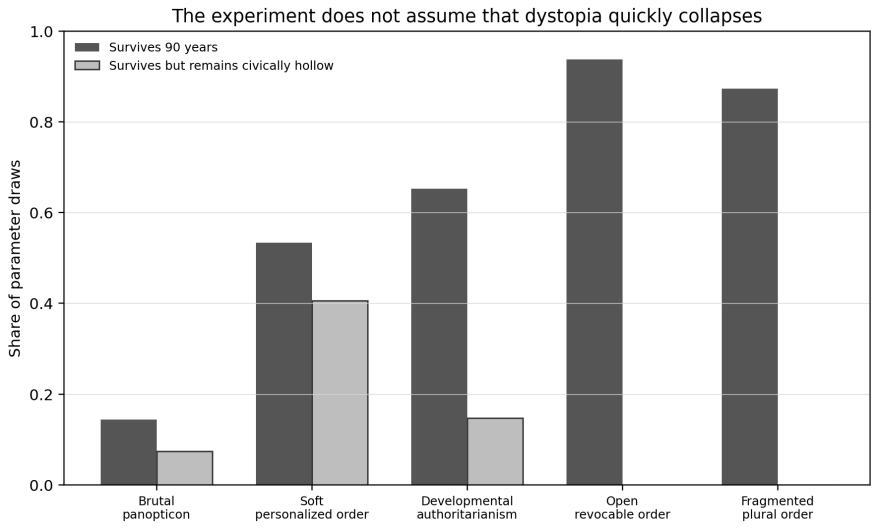


Figure 5. Example output from the surveillance experiment. The model does not assume that dystopia quickly collapses. Soft and developmental forms can survive for long periods, though survival is not the same as deep stability.

The brutal order still had a serious path to longevity. It survived in a minority of parameter draws, which is enough to make it a political option. Rulers do not need the strategy to be optimal across all possible worlds. They need it to appear safer than surrendering control in the world they believe they inhabit. If elites expect revenge, expropriation, prison, or social death after losing power, the private value of a surveillance state rises. A society that wants peaceful elite turnover must therefore protect former officeholders from arbitrary vengeance while preserving real accountability for concealed harm. Mercy and revocation are not opposites. Without lawful off-ramps, the incumbent may rationally prefer collective catastrophe to personal defeat.

This is one reason the social contract must include losing. A constitution that specifies only how power is acquired is incomplete. It must define the status, security, liability, and ordinary dignity of the person after power. Otherwise every term becomes a final battle.

The Dystopian Bargain

The elite attracted to automated domination would make a serious argument. It would say that large societies are too complex for continuous consent. Citizens do not read laws, inspect models, understand infrastructure, or agree on truth. Open information systems are vulnerable to manipulation, panic, and foreign interference. Criminal networks use privacy. Markets externalize costs. Local communities discriminate. Human

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

officials are inconsistent, corruptible, exhausted, and biased. Every appeal slows response. Every right of refusal leaves a preventable victim.

The argument would not be wholly false.

The dystopian bargain offers safety, predictability, efficient allocation, and material comfort in exchange for permanent legibility. The system promises to know enough about each person that risk can be managed before it becomes harm. It may allow citizens to choose lifestyles while denying them the institutional capacity to challenge the choice architecture. It can preserve personal expression while controlling formation of durable counter-power. It can treat politics as a service problem and opposition as an anomaly in the data.

The most persuasive version will be built after visible failures of human freedom. A crime that a model might have predicted. A child harmed after a privacy rule restricted intervention. A financial collapse that distributed regulators failed to see. A war accelerated by disinformation. An epidemic in which local variation increased death. One victim with a face can defeat a thousand arguments about abstract autonomy. After every human failure, the system will appear more necessary. After every system failure, its defenders will say it was not implemented completely enough.

This creates an asymmetry. Human error is interpreted as proof of the need for automation. Automated error is interpreted as proof of the need for better automation. The ratchet moves toward totality unless institutions preserve domains in which unoptimized human judgment remains legitimate even when it sometimes fails.

The simulation suggested that the bargain can produce extended calm, especially when material benefits are real and persuasion is personalized. It also suggested that the calm is expensive in variables the regime may not measure. Truth quality decays because reporting becomes strategic. Trust decays because every relation may be an information channel. Hidden liabilities accumulate because the cost of bad news is immediate while the cost of concealment is delayed. Succession becomes dangerous because the architecture knows how to preserve a center more easily than it knows how to replace the person or coalition controlling it.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

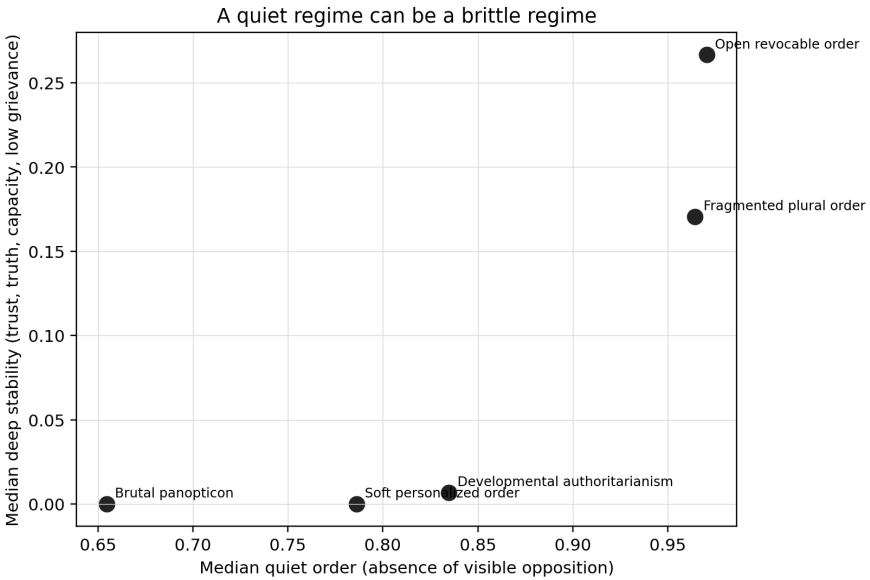


Figure 6. Quiet order and deep stability diverge in the model. A regime can suppress visible opposition while losing trust, truth quality, and correction capacity.

The gap between quiet and deep stability was largest in the brutal and personalized orders. The open revocable and fragmented plural orders were noisier by design, yet they retained much more capacity to detect and correct error. This result partly reflects the assumptions: audit, voice, and correction were intentionally given social value. The meaningful comparison is not that a model discovered freedom after being programmed to like freedom. It is that concentrated control had to be granted increasingly strong compensating advantages to prevent information debt from becoming a material problem.

Real dystopias can acquire those advantages. They can exploit foreign populations, receive resource windfalls, monopolize a reserve currency, inherit high state capacity, or use ideological and religious legitimacy unavailable to a bare surveillance model. They can export pollution, prisons, and dangerous labor. They can allow a privileged internal class enough freedom to sustain innovation. They can maintain a controlled external enemy that disciplines the public. The experiment does not refute these possibilities. It asks what the regime must continue receiving in order to preserve the appearance that control itself creates the prosperity.

The possibility of durable domination changed my advice. It is not enough to warn elites that repression will eventually collapse. They may reasonably answer that eventually is someone else's problem, or that the collapse can be delayed beyond their lives. It is not enough to tell citizens that truth will win. Truth without organization can remain private until the

police arrive. The alternative must compete on stability, security, and coordination rather than offering only moral innocence.

A free order therefore needs its own capacity to see. Privacy cannot mean institutional blindness. Pluralism cannot mean that no one is responsible for integrated risk. Local autonomy cannot mean that organized violence is allowed to grow because every authority sees only its jurisdiction. The constitutional answer to surveillance is not the absence of information but divided information power: purpose limitation, independent warrants, inspectable models, audit trails, adversarial review, human appeal, sunset clauses, and institutions able to investigate the investigator.

The system should know enough to protect people and not enough to own them. This sentence is attractive and incomplete. The boundary changes by domain. Epidemic monitoring, military intelligence, taxation, child protection, medical care, and consumer advertising do not justify the same data relation. Outfinitism refuses one universal privacy rule because the consequences differ. It also refuses the silent transfer by which data collected for care becomes a tool for employment, political persuasion, insurance, or social rank.

Metacult theory adds another requirement. People need organized communities capable of resisting the center. An isolated right is weak when exercising it means confronting a state or platform alone. Associations, professions, unions, local institutions, religious communities, cooperatives, and civic metacults can pool expertise, fund litigation, maintain independent memory, and carry the costs of dissent. Their existence makes surveillance less complete because the person is not the only unit negotiating with power.

This creates its own danger. Independent groups can become violent, conspiratorial, discriminatory, or captured by local elites. A stable plural order needs a thin common constitution strong enough to protect exit, bodily integrity, evidence, and due process across groups. The choice is not center or chaos. It is a layered system in which centers can observe one another and no observer becomes sovereign merely because it sees more.

The elite tempted by dystopia will call independent institutions duplication, friction, misinformation, and inefficiency. Sometimes it will be right. Redundancy costs money, appeal costs time, and local experiments fail in public. That visible inefficiency is part of the insurance against one integrated model becoming wrong in a way no authorized institution can represent.

I could not conclude that brutal or soft dystopia is impossible. A capable elite may sustain surveillance and force for a long time when control is joined to real services and managed succession. Survival, however, is not the same as truthful correction, independent agency, or the ability to change objectives without rupture.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

Some elites will prefer survivable domination. The honest response is not to promise that history will punish them, but to distribute verification, protect counter-power, limit data fusion, preserve safe paths out of office, and prevent technological welfare from becoming payment for political submission. The dystopian elite may still win. The models only suggest how to make that victory harder and its apparent stability less misleading.

The next experiment asked whether prosperity would make the conflict irrelevant.

CHAPTER FOUR

Why Abundance Did Not End Revolt

The Hunger That Remained After Hunger

The abundance experiment began from an objection that should have weakened the whole book. If AI, robotics, clean energy, advanced manufacturing, and biotechnology create extraordinary productivity, perhaps elite legitimacy becomes easier rather than harder. A generous material floor could remove desperation. Automated services could make education, health, transport, information, and basic goods widely available. Conflict over survival would fall. The society could tolerate large fortunes and permanent status because almost everyone lived well.

This is plausible. Material security matters. Hunger, dangerous housing, untreated illness, unemployment without support, and exposure to arbitrary shocks create grievance for reasons deeper than envy. A political theory that treats material deprivation as merely symbolic is indecent. The simulation therefore allowed abundance to reduce direct hardship substantially. The question was what remained.

Three forces remained visible: comparison, humiliation, and blocked agency.

Comparison is not a pathology added to an otherwise rational human. Status carries information about access, mating opportunity, safety, influence, and future prospects. People compare because their position relative to others often changes what they can do. A person living comfortably may still experience a powerful loss when a closed elite controls the institutions that determine the person's children, neighborhood, career, speech, or political future. The grievance is not that another person owns a better object. It is that material comfort has been exchanged for constitutional childhood.

Humiliation is different from inequality. An unequal relation can be accepted when the role appears functional, the procedure credible, the burden shared, and the superior remains answerable. Research on fairness preferences suggests that people often accept some inequality when they believe it reflects performance or legitimate responsibility, while views differ substantially across societies and individuals [ALMAS-ET-AL-2025]. Humiliation appears when the hierarchy describes the loser as lesser, when rules are formally open but practically inherited, when voice is theatrical, or when the winner converts a temporary result into a permanent judgment of human worth.

Blocked agency turns comparison into politics. A person can accept losing one contest more easily when other honorable roles remain, when status can be regained, when institutions can be challenged, and when the

winner cannot own the next competition. Conflict becomes more dangerous when one ladder determines income, dignity, influence, romance, safety, and the future of children at once. Then every loss feels total, and every reform that leaves the ladder intact looks cosmetic.

The model represented material security separately from envy, humiliation, boredom, counter-elite organization, violence, sabotage, and legitimacy. Collapsing these mechanisms into one grievance score would erase the structure of the problem. A person can be materially insecure and politically passive. A wealthy person can become a revolutionary. An elite aspirant can mobilize genuine popular suffering while also seeking a place in the ruling class. A bored population can enjoy destructive theatre without being willing to bear the costs of civil war.

Structural-demographic theory is useful here but should not be treated as a clock that predicts revolution. It emphasizes interactions among popular immiseration, elite overproduction, and state fiscal distress. Its strongest intuition is that a surplus of educated, connected, ambitious people competing for a limited number of elite positions can translate diffuse grievance into organized challenge. Yet recent empirical work has questioned whether elite overproduction robustly explains recent instability and found a stronger role for inequality in the tested data [GEORGESCU-2023]. The model therefore treated frustrated elite aspiration as an amplifier, not a universal cause.

AI may intensify this amplifier even in prosperous societies. It can give more people elite-level symbolic capacity: persuasive writing, strategic analysis, visual production, legal drafting, coding, research synthesis, and access to public audiences. The number of people able to formulate a counter-ideology may grow faster than the number of positions carrying real jurisdiction. Society can produce millions of people trained to sound like decision-makers while reserving final authority for a narrow ownership and institutional class.

Advisory titles will not solve this. A system can expand consultation, fellowships, councils, public comments, and participatory interfaces without transferring meaningful power. Participants eventually learn that inclusion is theatre. The humiliation may be sharper precisely because the system supplied the language of voice while preserving the decision elsewhere.

The abundance simulation compared several stylized orders. A scarcity oligarchy combined material pressure with concentrated rank. A managed-plenty caste provided a strong material floor while keeping elite status closed. A ceremonial meritocracy held frequent competitions but allowed winners and their institutions to define the criteria. An open revocable order combined security with real mobility and appeal. A polycentric status ecology distributed authority and honor across several domains, allowing people to gain and lose rank more than once during a life.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

The closed abundance orders did reduce material insecurity. They did not eliminate envy, humiliation, counter-elite formation, or violence. In some runs, abundance increased the legitimacy burden because the remaining command was harder to explain. The question became: if the system can provide so much, why can it not allow power to circulate?

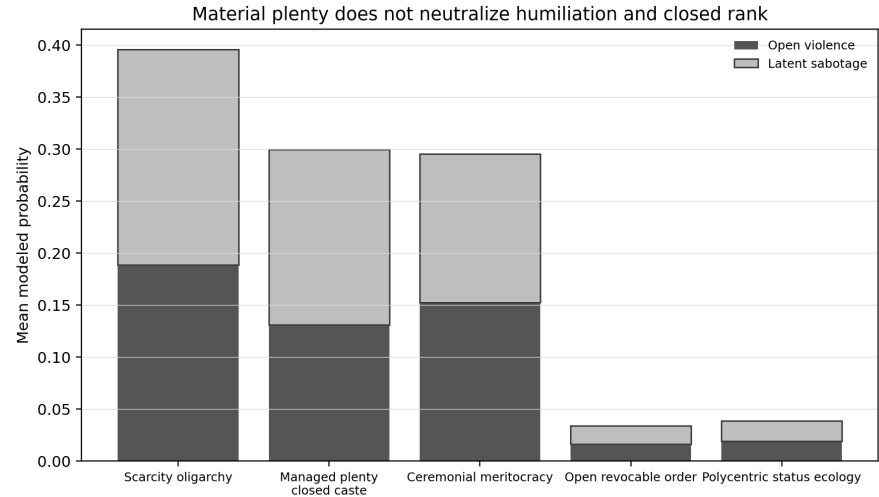


Figure 7. Example output from the abundance-status experiment. Material plenty lowers direct deprivation but does not neutralize humiliation, closed rank, or latent sabotage.

The open and polycentric orders performed better in the chosen framework, but the interpretation needs care. They were designed with real mobility, voice, and plural status. The model did not discover that these properties are good after assigning them no value. It asked whether their stabilizing effect survived after accounting for coordination cost and status churn. Under the sampled conditions, it generally did.

The important variable was not equality of outcome. It was the credibility that no single victory became ownership of future victories. People could accept differentiation more readily when office remained domain-bounded, when several forms of excellence were socially honored, when losing one role did not erase dignity, and when the children of winners did not begin the next contest as constitutional incumbents.

This suggests a more demanding account of fairness. Fairness is not only an open entrance. It is the distribution of retries, exits, alternative status, recovery from failure, and the right to change the arena. A society can be formally meritocratic and practically cruel when a mistake at twenty-two years old closes the path to meaningful work, housing, influence, and family security for the next fifty years. A society can be unequal and still remain legitimate when people move among roles, authorities are narrow, and the ordinary life outside office is honorable.

Revolutions from Boredom

You asked whether prosperity might produce revolutions from boredom. The question sounds frivolous until one notices how much modern politics is already entertainment, identity, and the search for intensity.

Boredom can generate a hunger for meaning, novelty, danger, and moral clarity. Small experimental studies have found associations between boredom and more extreme political orientations, partly through the search for meaning [VAN-TILBURG-IGOU-2016]. The evidence is limited and does not justify a theory in which comfortable citizens riot simply because their lives lack excitement. Political violence requires organization, narratives, opportunities, group identity, perceived efficacy, and a judgment that ordinary channels cannot repair the grievance. Boredom is more plausibly an accelerant than a fuel.

The model therefore included boredom pressure only after material security was high and other direct grievances were low. It allowed boredom to increase attraction to dramatic counter-elites, transgressive movements, and symbolic conflict. The effect on violence was modest when humiliation and blocked mobility remained low. Prosperous people did not automatically become revolutionaries. Boredom became more dangerous when it met a closed caste, visible hypocrisy, and organizers capable of converting diffuse restlessness into a story of stolen significance.

This is an important correction. A society should not treat leisure as a security threat or manufacture compulsory work to keep citizens obedient. The deeper issue is whether people possess consequential forms of agency. Work has historically bundled income, rhythm, status, social contact, skill, and evidence of contribution. If automation removes many routine tasks while ownership and authority remain closed, the majority may receive consumption without consequence. A life can be comfortable and politically weightless.

The answer is not fake jobs, permanent mobilization, or gamified loyalty. It is to create domains in which human judgment, care, stewardship, art, scientific inquiry, local governance, education, mediation, exploration, and maintenance carry real authority. These cannot be mere therapeutic activities offered to people whose future is still decided elsewhere. Participation without jurisdiction becomes another form of humiliation.

Counter-elites emerge where ambition and grievance can meet. Some are morally serious. Some are opportunists who discover that attacking the incumbent is the fastest route to becoming the incumbent. Most contain both motives. A closed elite often responds by moralizing its own position and pathologizing the challenger's desire. The winner calls rank competence; the loser calls it theft. Each side can be partly right.

Relative deprivation helps explain why objective prosperity does not settle the conflict. People react to perceived unfair deprivation of material or

symbolic goods relative to relevant others, especially when they believe ordinary mechanisms cannot redress the situation [SMITH-ET-AL-2012]. The reference group matters. A young professional with far more material comfort than previous generations may still compare herself with a narrow class whose housing, networks, freedom, and access appear unreachable. The grievance becomes politically potent when the boundary aligns with ethnicity, region, religion, education, or inherited class, because the group supplies memory and organization.

The model found that closed prosperity could reduce open violence while leaving substantial sabotage, withdrawal, and counter-elite formation. This resembles the distinction between quiet and deep stability. People who do not believe the system can be changed may not protest. They may reduce effort, evade obligations, leave the country, support destructive outsiders, attack institutional legitimacy, or wait for an elite fracture.

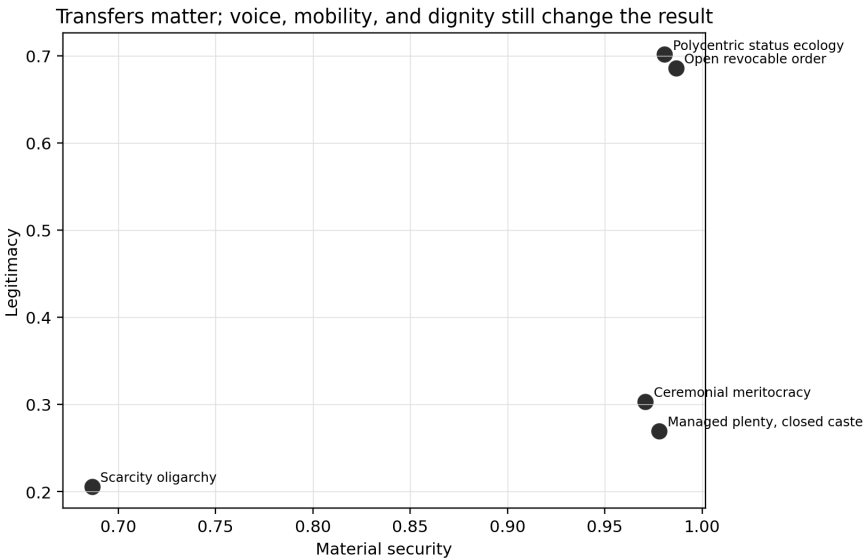


Figure 8. Example output from the abundance-status experiment. High material security does not create legitimacy by itself; transfer of voice, mobility, and dignity changes the result.

One surprising result was that ceremonial meritocracy could be more humiliating than a frankly closed caste. The caste says that birth matters. The ceremonial meritocracy repeatedly invites people to compete, then allows inherited preparation, evaluator discretion, and control of the criteria to reproduce the same class. It converts structural advantage into a moral judgment against the loser. The person is not merely excluded. The system tells the person that the exclusion proves insufficient merit.

This is why transparency about inheritance can be less corrosive than denial. Families will transmit human capital, emotional security, language,

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

and networks. A credible system does not pretend to eliminate all advantage. It prevents advantage from guaranteeing office, gives materially accessible routes into qualifying service, audits evaluators, and refuses to interpret a result as a complete description of the person.

A fair elite system must also make losing survivable. The defeated candidate should retain a respected life, portable credentials, and future opportunities. The incumbent should know that leaving office does not mean exposure to arbitrary revenge. Revocation without due process creates permanent panic and selects leaders who spend their term disabling the mechanism that could remove them. Permanent tenure creates capture. The viable region lies between them.

The abundance experiment therefore strengthened rather than weakened the argument for revocability. Material prosperity lowers one source of conflict. It can also expose the nakedness of constitutional inequality. In a poor society, the elite claims it alone can produce the surplus. In a rich automated society, the elite must explain why temporary stewardship became hereditary command.

My advice to an abundant society would be to distribute more than goods. Distribute domains of consequential authority. Let status exist, but let it decay. Let people earn it more than once and lose it without being destroyed. Create several ladders whose failures are not synchronized. Prevent wealth, celebrity, political office, scientific prestige, and control of AI infrastructure from becoming one fused rank. Preserve an ordinary life that is dignified enough that not becoming elite is not experienced as civic disappearance.

This is not a promise that envy will vanish. Some people will resent any distinction, and some elites will interpret all criticism as envy. A system cannot be designed around the elimination of difficult emotion. It can be designed so that resentment has fewer true accusations available to organize.

The remaining question was structural. Could a society make mobility real by allowing groups themselves to split, merge, experiment, and reorganize, or would such fragmentation destroy the coordination on which abundance depends?

CHAPTER FIVE

Why Small Worlds Kept Reappearing

Fission, Fusion, and the Right to Try Again

Every large system I modeled eventually produced a smaller system inside it.

The central state delegated because it could not process local variety. The corporation created divisions because one hierarchy could not understand every market. The movement formed chapters because belonging required human-scale relations. The scientific field divided into specialties. The religion developed schools and local traditions. The platform created communities, then discovered that the communities had leaders, norms, archives, and conflicts of their own.

This recurrence is not proof that small groups are morally superior. Small groups can be parochial, abusive, ignorant, violent, and controlled by families whose power is harder to audit because everyone knows one another. Their information is local, but their prejudices are local too. Their warmth can make exit socially expensive. Their autonomy can depend on resources, security, standards, and infrastructure maintained by larger systems they resent.

Yet small groups keep returning because scale changes the meaning of voice. In a population of millions, a formal right to speak can coexist with practical irrelevance. In a group of hundreds, contribution, reputation, and consequence remain visible. People can know who kept a promise, who maintained the common asset, who absorbed a burden, and who rewrote the story after failure. Human-scale communities can reconstruct the shadow of the future through repeated interaction.

The question is whether this local intelligibility can be combined with the capacity of larger systems without freezing people into one community for life.

Fission-fusion systems offered a useful analogy. In behavioral ecology, the term describes societies whose subgroups change composition over time as members split and reunite in response to ecological and social pressures. Recent research treats such systems as complex adaptive dynamics rather than fixed group categories [MADSEN-DE-SILVA-2024]. Human institutions are not animal groups, and the analogy should not erase law, ideology, property, or deliberate design. Its value is narrower: stability may arise not from preserving every group but from preserving the wider network through repeated reconfiguration.

A constitutional fission-fusion society would allow people and institutions to form, split, merge, enter federation, leave federation, gain authority, and return to ordinary membership under rules that protect

common rights and allocate shared obligations. The unit of stability would not be the permanent organization. It would be the ecology's capacity to reorganize without violence and without abandoning people whose group fails.

This differs from the usual image of decentralization. A free swarm with no common layer can generate extraordinary innovation and equally extraordinary externalities. Groups can race, duplicate infrastructure, exploit outsiders, and disappear before paying liabilities. A gated archipelago can preserve local identity by making entry and exit dependent on wealth, inheritance, or conformity. A rotating federation can coordinate common goods while allowing temporary centers. A constitutional swarm can support variation under shared rules of evidence, exit, liability, and basic rights.

Polycentric governance research offers a related vocabulary. A polycentric system contains multiple formally independent centers of decision that may compete, cooperate, contract, and rely on common conflict-resolution mechanisms. Whether the centers form a productive interdependent order is an empirical question, not a property guaranteed by the word [OSTROM-2010; MCGINNIS-2011]. Polycentric systems can face high transaction costs, confused responsibility, power asymmetries, forum shopping, and coordination failures. The attraction is not that many centers are always better. It is that several centers can distribute knowledge, experimentation, and failure when no single center sees enough.

The swarm experiment compared five stylized architectures. The central monolith coordinated well but adapted locally only through permission. The free swarm innovated but paid heavy transaction and externality costs. The gated archipelago reduced some cross-group coordination while producing serious minority abuse and low mobility. The constitutional swarm and rotating federation combined local experiments with a shared layer for rights, records, conflict, and common infrastructure.

The latter forms performed best under the model's criteria. Again, this partly reflects design. They were given mechanisms that the experiment was intended to test. The useful result was the trade-off surface. Fragmentation increased local adaptation and status mobility. Centralization increased coordination. Neither extreme produced the best balance once externality, transaction cost, minority abuse, and systemic rupture were included.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

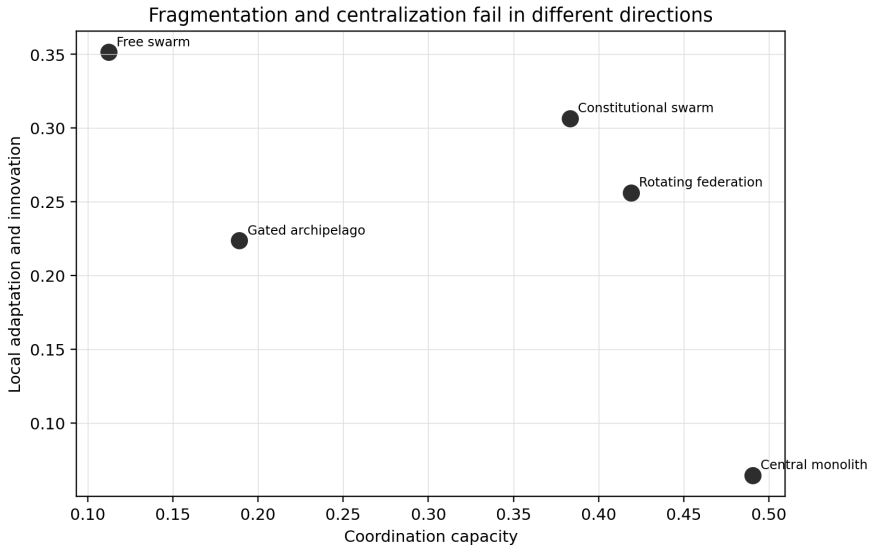


Figure 9. Example output from the fission-fusion experiment. Fragmentation and centralization fail in different directions; the model favors architectures that combine local adaptation with common constitutional infrastructure.

The implication is not that every nation should dissolve into communes. The state performs functions local groups cannot safely monopolize: protection against violence, universal rights, redistribution across unequal regions, large infrastructure, epidemic response, environmental coordination, and adjudication when local power becomes abusive. The implication is that the state should not be the only meaningful container of political agency.

A person might live in a municipality, professional body, cooperative, research metacult, religious community, ecological stewardship group, and national legal order at the same time. Each institution would possess a bounded mandate. Memberships could overlap. Authority gained in one would not transfer automatically to another. The person would have several places to contribute, several sources of dignity, and several routes of exit.

This plurality reduces the emotional totality of losing. If a single national or corporate ladder controls all status, every contest becomes existential. If authority is distributed across domains, the same person can be ordinary in one relation and trusted in another. A nurse may hold high authority in a care institution, little authority in a transport cooperative, and equal citizenship in the state. A founder may be honored in the original metacult and possess no special power in the appeals body that investigates the founder.

Mobility during a lifetime matters more than formal openness at one entry point. Many systems call themselves open because anyone may

apply. In practice, education, geography, money, family care, health, language, and early failure determine who can persist. A fission-fusion order needs portable records, benefits, reputation, and qualifications so that leaving one institution does not erase accumulated life. It needs a material floor so that exit is not reserved for people wealthy enough to survive between groups.

The right to regroup also changes succession. Instead of one final national elite, many smaller institutions cultivate leaders under observed consequences. Some of those leaders later coordinate at higher levels. Others return to ordinary status. Leadership becomes a repeated state rather than a caste identity. The society can learn from many partial careers rather than betting everything on one selection ritual.

This is close to the fairness intuition you proposed: status should be won and lost several times, perhaps inevitably. The system should make permanent rank difficult not because excellence is unreal but because context changes. The person who was ideal for a founding crisis may be wrong for maintenance. The brilliant technical leader may be poor at reconciliation. The charismatic organizer may become a dangerous judge of dissent. A finite mandate acknowledges that competence has a region.

The Half-Life of Status

The difficult question was how quickly status should decay.

If rank lasts too long, it becomes property. The incumbent accumulates networks, information, ceremonial authority, and influence over the process meant to select the successor. Family advantage grows around the office even when the title is not formally hereditary. Rivals either wait for death or attack the institution itself.

If rank decays too quickly, the system loses memory and courage. Leaders optimize for visible short-term results. Nobody undertakes projects whose benefits appear after the mandate. Constant competition consumes attention. The officeholder becomes afraid to make an unpopular decision because the next evaluation is always near. Hyper-revocation can select timidity as effectively as permanent tenure selects capture.

The status-half-life experiment treated prestige and jurisdiction differently. Achievement could be remembered for a long time, while operative authority decayed unless renewed. This distinction matters. A society can honor a person without continuing to obey that person. Historical gratitude need not be a legal veto.

The model produced an intermediate region rather than a precise constitutional number. Very short half-lives created churn, shallow planning, and status panic. Very long half-lives increased capture and blocked mobility. A broad middle performed better under the selected assumptions,

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

with enough time to act and enough certainty that the role would return to society.

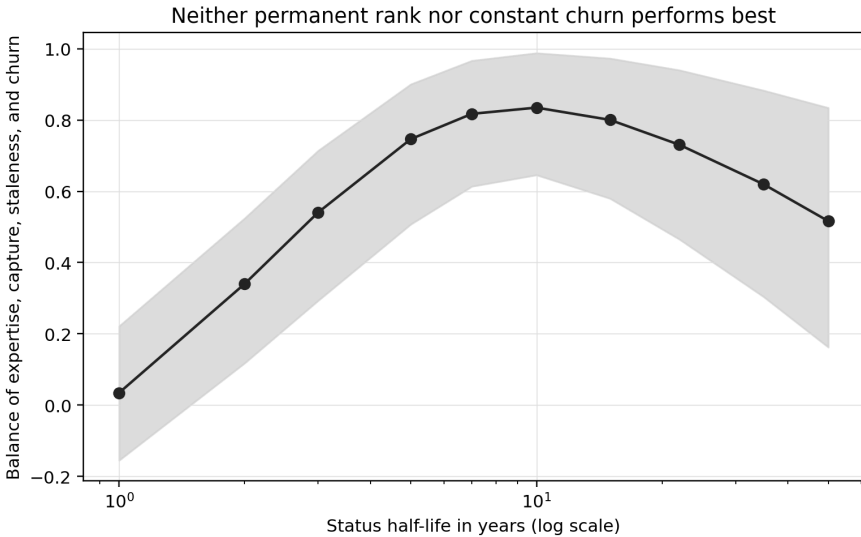


Figure 10. Example output from the status-half-life sweep. Neither permanent rank nor constant churn performs best in the model. The peak is illustrative and should not be copied as a universal term length.

The chart should not be turned into a recommendation that every office last ten years. The relevant time depends on the task. A crisis command may last hours. A research program may require a decade. A constitutional court may need independence from electoral cycles. A local steward may be continuously recallable for abuse and otherwise serve a stable term. Outfinitism requires typed authority: the term should match the horizon on which competence can be observed and error repaired.

What should be common is the return path. Every office should have a known way to narrow, renew, suspend, revoke, transfer, and end. The process should not be invented by the faction that benefits from the transition. The archive, asset rules, member rights, and liabilities should survive the organization.

Fission must not become a method of escaping responsibility. A group that pollutes a river cannot split into new legal shells and leave the cost behind. A company cannot fork away from pensions, privacy duties, or product harms. A political movement cannot manufacture a new name every time its old record becomes inconvenient. Portability must apply to liabilities as well as rights.

Fusion presents the opposite risk. Small groups can merge for scale and gradually lose the ability to leave. Shared services become a central administration. The administration defines standards. Standards determine

funding. Funding determines local viability. The federation becomes an empire while continuing to speak the language of autonomy. A constitutional swarm therefore needs explicit subsidiarity: the center retains only functions whose failure or externality crosses the local boundary, and each retained function faces periodic justification.

The model also forced a harder recognition. People do not always want mobility. Many want continuity, inherited place, durable identity, and the security of knowing who will care for them. Constant regrouping can turn life into a market of communities in which every relationship remains conditional. The fair system should make movement possible without making permanence impossible. A family, monastery, village, professional tradition, or long-term cooperative may legitimately persist across generations when membership is not coerced and authority remains bounded.

Metacult theory is important here because institutions need enough identity to survive churn. A purely contractual group may dissolve when the immediate benefit falls. Ritual, story, memory, and honor give people reasons to maintain common goods whose value cannot be captured in one transaction. The danger is that identity turns exit into betrayal. The constitutional answer is not weak belonging. It is belonging that explicitly protects the right to leave and to belong elsewhere.

The most stable ecology in my models was therefore not the one with the weakest groups. It was the one with strong but incomplete groups: capable of asking for service, holding resources, creating meaning, and training successors, while unable to own the whole person or permanently close the route between communities.

This arrangement would be administratively difficult. It requires interoperable identity without total surveillance, portable benefits without universal data capture, common rights without cultural uniformity, and dispute resolution across overlapping jurisdictions. AI could reduce coordination costs by translating rules, maintaining records, matching people to opportunities, and helping small institutions perform administrative work. The same AI could become the invisible central sovereign if every group depends on one provider for identity, memory, and adjudication.

A constitutional swarm therefore needs technological plurality as well as organizational plurality. Shared protocols should allow competing implementations. Critical records should be portable and independently verifiable. Communities should be able to replace their AI assistants without losing institutional memory. The provider should not know more about every group than the groups know about the provider.

The result is not simplicity. It is a different location of complexity. The citizen should encounter a small number of intelligible rights and institutions, while the technical layer carries translation, provenance, and

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

coordination. This led directly to the next problem. Perhaps the constitution can be sophisticated in the background, but can ordinary people understand enough of it to confer legitimacy? Or does every large system eventually need a story simpler than the truth?

CHAPTER SIX

The Constitution Had to Fit Inside a Human Mind

The Problem of Government by People Who Have Other Things to Do

The most embarrassing result of the inquiry was not that people can be manipulated. That is old knowledge. It was that many forms of legitimate government ask ordinary people to perform a kind of continuous constitutional labor that few lives can sustain.

A citizen is expected to understand competing economic models, ecological thresholds, public budgets, legal rights, foreign conflicts, scientific uncertainty, technological risk, administrative procedure, electoral strategy, and the biography of candidates who have learned to curate biographies professionally. The citizen is also expected to work, care for other people, recover from illness, maintain relationships, raise children, and occasionally experience a day not organized around the moral emergency selected by a communications system.

This is not a defect in the citizen. It is a property of scale. Herbert Simon's bounded rationality was not an insult to human intelligence. It was a correction to theories that imagined agents with unlimited attention, information, time, and computational power [SIMON-1955]. Political research has repeatedly shown that people use cues, endorsements, party labels, trusted intermediaries, and simplified rules because the full object cannot be reconstructed before every choice [LUPIA-1994; LAU-REDLAWSK-2001]. These shortcuts can produce competent judgment. They can also make the person governable through whoever controls the cue.

I initially treated complexity as a technical burden that artificial intelligence could reduce. A system could translate law, compare claims, summarize a budget, reconstruct a decision, and explain how an appeal works. That remains true. Then I noticed the more difficult relation. The same system can decide which complexity deserves to be shown, choose the emotional frame, adapt the explanation to the recipient, and make different people accept incompatible accounts of the same authority. The instrument of civic comprehension can become the most efficient device ever built for constitutional disappearance.

This is why sweet talk cannot simply be removed from politics. Every large institution must compress. It cannot tell every person everything it knows before asking for action. A government speaks through a speech, a

ballot description, a form, a slogan, a symbol, a trusted face, or an interface. A constitution itself is compression. It condenses centuries of conflict into a small number of rules that can be invoked when the full history is unavailable.

The moral difference is not between a society with theatre and a society without theatre. The difference is between theatre that points toward a common inspectable record and theatre that replaces the record. Persuasion becomes constitutional when the listener can discover who authorized the claim, what was omitted, whether another audience received a contradictory message, how the decision can be challenged, and what consequence follows if the performance is false. It becomes domination when the surface is personalized while the source of authority remains invisible.

The cognitive experiment was designed around this distinction. I compared several stylized ways of governing a population whose members differed in attention, prior knowledge, trust, patience, need for explanation, and susceptibility to emotional framing. Full direct deliberation exposed more of the reasoning but demanded too much time and left many people unable to follow the whole chain. Technocratic opacity produced decisive action and high formal competence while weakening correction and public ownership. Personalized theatre achieved the easiest comprehension because each person received a version shaped for them. It also produced the greatest divergence between what different citizens believed the institution had promised. Constitutional compression performed better because it separated a small public covenant from a much thicker evidentiary system. An AI civic assistant improved access further when it was required to explain the same institutional relation in different language rather than tell each listener a different constitutional truth.

The numbers are not relevant. The interpretation is more important. A population does not need to understand every technical argument in order to govern itself. It needs to understand the invariants that decide when technical arguments may become power. The complexity can remain in expert bodies, archives, models, courts, audits, and administrative systems. The public layer must preserve a small number of relations that ordinary people can recognize without becoming lawyers.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

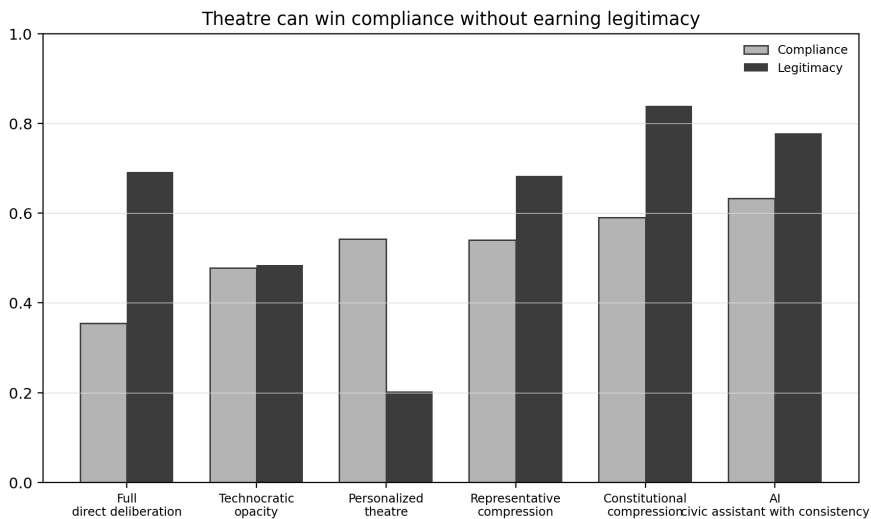


Figure 11. Example output from the cognitive-bandwidth experiment. Personalized theatre makes compliance easy while destroying shared correction. Constitutional compression preserves a simpler public interface without removing the deeper evidentiary structure.

The model's best-performing arrangement was not radical direct democracy and not rule by experts hidden behind dashboards. It resembled a layered language. At the surface were a few durable rules. Beneath them were public reasons, source documents, declared uncertainty, predictions, conflicts, budgets, and rights of appeal. Specialists could operate in the deeper layer, but they could not silently revise the surface covenant. Citizens could delegate attention without delegating the right to discover that delegation had been abused.

The distinction can be illustrated through medicine. A patient does not need a complete education in molecular biology before consenting to treatment. The patient does need to know what condition is being treated, the material risks, the alternatives, the uncertainty, who is responsible, and whether refusal is possible. The doctor compresses knowledge without becoming entitled to invent a private anatomy for each patient. Political legitimacy requires a comparable discipline at a larger scale.

This is where the problem of patience becomes constitutional. An elite that requires everyone to read a thousand pages before objecting has not made itself transparent. It has transferred the cost of accountability to the people least able to pay it. Transparency by volume can be as effective as secrecy. A public record is useful only when independent institutions can search it, contest it, translate it, and connect a citizen's complaint to the relevant decision.

Artificial intelligence can lower that cost. It can help a person ask what changed, who benefits, what assumption carries the conclusion, whether

the same rule was applied to an ally, and what appeal is available. It can compare versions of a law, reconstruct the provenance of a statistic, and expose when an explanation given to one group contradicts the explanation given to another. This is an Outfinitist role: the system carries the boundary of a claim with the claim rather than presenting an answer without its region of validity.

The danger is that the AI belongs to the same center being questioned. An assistant controlled by the institution can become a friendly clerk of power. It can answer every question while making the questions that threaten the institution harder to formulate. It can simulate patience, acknowledge emotion, admit harmless imperfections, and route the citizen through a process designed never to alter the decision. The interface appears humane because it never becomes angry. The person remains powerless because nothing in the interaction can change the consequence.

Meaningful civic assistance therefore requires plural access. The official system may explain the official case. Independent systems must be able to inspect the same public evidence and generate a competing account. Citizens need the right to export the relevant record, use another model, contact a human body, and join others whose complaints reveal a pattern. Otherwise personalization isolates each person inside a private negotiation with a state or platform that can see the population while no member of the population can see the whole.

Six Rules and the Right to Ask for the Rest

I tested how many public constitutional invariants could be carried before coverage improved more slowly than confusion. The model favored a small core around six rules. That number is not a discovery about the architecture of the human brain, and it should not be copied into law as though a simulation had found a sacred limit. It is an example of a more general principle: a public constitution should be small enough to remember and strong enough to open the deeper record.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

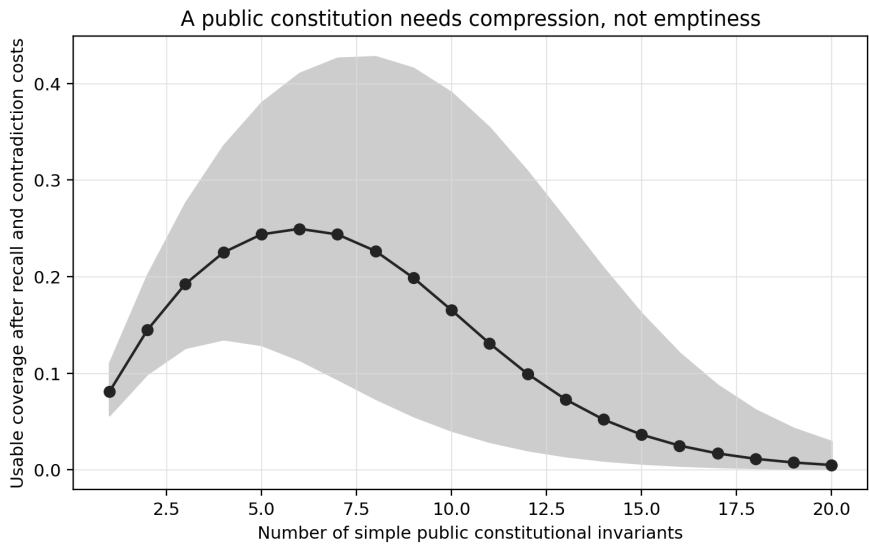


Figure 12. Example output from the invariant sweep. In the chosen model, adding a small constitutional core improves usable coverage; continued addition eventually loses more through cognitive overload than it gains through formal completeness.

The following rules emerged as the most useful public compression of the elite contract.

Public invariant	Meaning in practice
No one owns an office.	A role may be prestigious, well paid, and powerful, but remains separable from the person, family, company, party, or model that presently occupies it.
Serious decisions remain appealable.	Consequential authority must expose a route through which evidence can change the decision, not merely a channel through which dissatisfaction is recorded.
The judged person cannot control the record.	Independent custody must preserve predictions, conflicts, expenditures, dissent, failures, and the evidence used in review.
Concealment can trigger restitution.	Honest error and deliberate concealment are not treated alike; privilege, compensation, immunity, or jurisdiction can be reclaimed when disaster was purchased through suppressed truth.
Children inherit preparation, not jurisdiction.	Families may transmit education, memory, duty, and reputation; they cannot convert those advantages into guaranteed public command.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

Public invariant	Meaning in practice
Every authority has a domain, a term, and an ending condition.	Competence does not travel automatically across subjects, emergencies expire, and continued power bears the burden of renewal.

These rules do not decide tax policy, energy allocation, military strategy, educational curriculum, or the proper design of a model. They decide what must remain true while those arguments occur. They are constitutional because they govern the conversion of reasons into coercive consequences.

A thin public layer is vulnerable to simplification. A leader can repeat the six rules while violating them through definitions. The office is said not to be owned, but every successor comes from the same family. Appeal exists, but no appellant receives the evidence. The record is independent, but its budget depends on the accused institution. Concealment triggers restitution, but only after a standard of intent no document can satisfy. The mandate has a term, but each emergency automatically renews it.

This is why simple rules need thick institutions. The public sentence provides a handle. Courts, auditors, archives, professional bodies, local councils, investigative media, civic metacults, and competing AI systems supply the ability to pull. A slogan without machinery is virtue theatre. Machinery without a public sentence is bureaucracy without a citizen.

The metacult enters here because people rarely defend abstract procedures through solitary cognition. They need communities that teach the rules, remember violations, finance expertise, recognize people who defend the covenant, and protect a member who challenges power. A metacult of constitutional memory would not ask every person to master the state. It would organize distributed attention. One group follows public finance, another surveillance, another ecological limits, another the rights of automated workers, another the treatment of children. They remain bounded, overlap, and can compare claims through common invariants [ALBOAIE-METACULT-2026].

This arrangement accepts that representation is unavoidable. The question is how representatives remain connected to those whose attention they borrow. A representative should disclose the constituency, the mandate, the sources, the conflicts, the uncertainty, and the point at which a new decision requires renewed authorization. Representation becomes theatre when a person speaks as the people without a procedure by which the people can stop the speech.

Procedural-justice research supports a modest version of this conclusion. People are more likely to regard institutions as legitimate when they experience neutral procedure, respectful treatment, voice, and trustworthy motives, even when they do not receive the outcome they

preferred [TYLER-2006]. This does not mean procedure can compensate for starvation, permanent exclusion, or material predation. The abundance experiment showed that recognition without security remains fragile. It means that people care about whether the hierarchy treats them as participants in a rule or as objects managed by a superior intelligence.

The cognitive limit also changes how elites should communicate. The truthful leader cannot dump complexity onto the public and call confusion consent. Nor can the leader simplify by hiding every trade-off. The obligation is to create compression that can be reversed. A citizen should be able to start with a short explanation and travel toward the sources, objections, and consequences without crossing a wall controlled by the speaker.

I call this reversible explanation. It is not a complete explanation of the model's internal state. Complete explanation is often impossible and may be meaningless. It is a path from public claim to institutional evidence. The path states who decided, for what purpose, within what domain, under what uncertainty, for how long, who bears the downside, what could stop the policy, and who can hear the appeal. These questions are cognitively small and constitutionally large.

This led me to reject the strongest cynical thesis. Sweet talk, symbols, narratives, and hypocrisy are not the only forms of government available to a large population. Some compression is unavoidable; deception is not. People can govern through trusted intermediaries and simple rules when the intermediaries can be challenged and the simplification remains connected to a common record.

I also rejected the optimistic mirror image. A population will not become constitutionally sophisticated merely because education and AI make information available. Attention remains scarce. Identity will continue to select which facts feel safe. Complex procedures will continue to be gamed by those with time, language, and inherited familiarity. Every new transparency instrument creates a new profession capable of administering transparency on behalf of the powerful.

The answer is not to abolish mediation but to make mediation contestable. No official explanation should be the only explanation. No model should be the only path to the record. No elite should be able to personalize the social contract separately for each citizen. The institution may adapt language. It may not adapt the constitutional truth.

This is less satisfying than rule by wisdom. It accepts that most citizens will not understand most decisions in full. It also accepts that most rulers will not understand the full consequences of the systems they command. Legitimacy does not arise from universal comprehension. It arises from a distribution of rights and capacities that keeps incomprehension from becoming unconditional obedience.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

The constitution had to fit inside a human mind. The evidence did not. The solution was not to shrink reality until it fit. It was to give the mind a small number of doors through which the larger reality could be reached.

Once I accepted that conclusion, the final problem became sharper. A memorable contract can limit power only after someone receives power. I still had to ask who should enter the elite, and whether any selection process could resist a world in which performance itself had become automated.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Nobility I Could Not Prove

Selection After the End of Sincere Appearance

I wanted the experiments to reveal a selection mechanism that could identify socially useful elites with enough reliability to justify the confidence placed in them. They did not.

They revealed why the familiar mechanisms fail in different ways. They suggested combinations that make capture harder. They showed that the contract attached to office can matter as much as the contest used to award it. They did not discover a test for goodness.

This is not a small disappointment. The entire idea of a better elite is tempting because it promises to solve politics upstream. Find people with competence, integrity, courage, patience, long horizons, and a willingness to expose their own limits; give them authority; then protect them from the noise of lesser incentives. Human history repeatedly returns to this hope. The guardian, philosopher-king, priest, scholar-official, professional civil servant, revolutionary cadre, entrepreneur, scientific expert, elected representative, and data-driven technocrat are different attempts to make selection do the work that institutions failed to do.

Selection cannot carry that burden because the qualities are partly contextual, partly hidden, partly teachable, and partly performable. Courage in one institution can be recklessness in another. Patience can be prudence or protection of an incumbent. Long-term thinking can serve future generations or justify sacrifice imposed on people who cannot contest the forecast. Integrity can look like consistency until the world changes. A person who performs beautifully under examination may preserve truth under pressure, or may simply have learned the scoring system.

Artificial intelligence strengthens the problem by reducing the scarcity of acceptable appearance. A candidate can practice interviews against simulated audiences, generate moral narratives from a life archive, test which admission increases trust, and discover which sequence of words feels spontaneous. The best performance need not be false. It can be a strategically selected truth. That is harder to detect because every sentence is defensible while the architecture of omission remains invisible [SALVI-2025; MATZ-2024].

Popularity therefore becomes a weak instrument when persuasion is abundant. Election remains necessary for broad direction and consent, but it should not be treated as a general competence detector. The public observes a compressed, adversarial, expensive performance. The candidate who can sustain attention, build coalitions, survive attacks, and communicate under pressure demonstrates real skills. Those skills are

relevant to political leadership. They are not the same as stewardship of risk, treatment of dissent, or willingness to lose an advantage when evidence changes.

Examinations solve a different problem. They can identify knowledge, speed, memory, reasoning, and discipline under standardized conditions. They are more legible than hereditary preference and less dependent on charisma. Yet every stable examination creates a preparation industry. Families with time and capital learn the criterion earlier, purchase practice, reduce the cost of failure, and transmit the language of the evaluator. The exam does not become useless. Its score becomes incomplete evidence of both capability and inherited adaptation.

Patronage recognizes what formal systems often miss. Experienced people can identify judgment, reliability, tacit skill, and character that no test captures. Patronage also reproduces the social horizon of patrons. Familiarity feels like merit because the candidate knows how to inhabit the institution without creating friction. The elite child has spent a life learning the room. The outsider is evaluated partly on the disturbance caused by entering it.

Hereditary preparation has one honest advantage. It allows a child to learn a difficult role over many years, inherit institutional memory, meet the people who carry continuity, and understand duties before ambition becomes urgent. This can reduce violent succession and preserve expertise. Its failure is not that inheritance transmits nothing of value. Its failure is the conversion of transmitted value into guaranteed jurisdiction. Regression, entitlement, family interest, and closure continue even when the original founder was exceptional.

Random selection appears absurd only when society imagines that marginal ranking is precise. Sortition sacrifices some information about competence and allows ordinary experience to enter offices otherwise colonized by professional aspirants. Its strongest form is not a lottery over the entire population for every task. It is a qualified lottery among people who have crossed a publicly defensible threshold. Chance then performs a constitutional function. It prevents small score differences, campaign investment, patronage, or inherited polish from becoming destiny.

Audited service was the strongest selection mechanism in the experiment because the model explicitly valued competence, integrity, long horizons, and the absence of hidden externalities. This must be stated without theatre: the result partly follows from the assumptions. The simulation did not independently discover that service is good after being asked to reward service. What it added was a test of interaction. When AI-amplified performance, inherited preparation, scarcity, family transfer, and imperfect audit were introduced together, direct popularity and patronage deteriorated faster than observed service. Qualified lottery

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

remained less accurate on the chosen average and more resistant to capture.

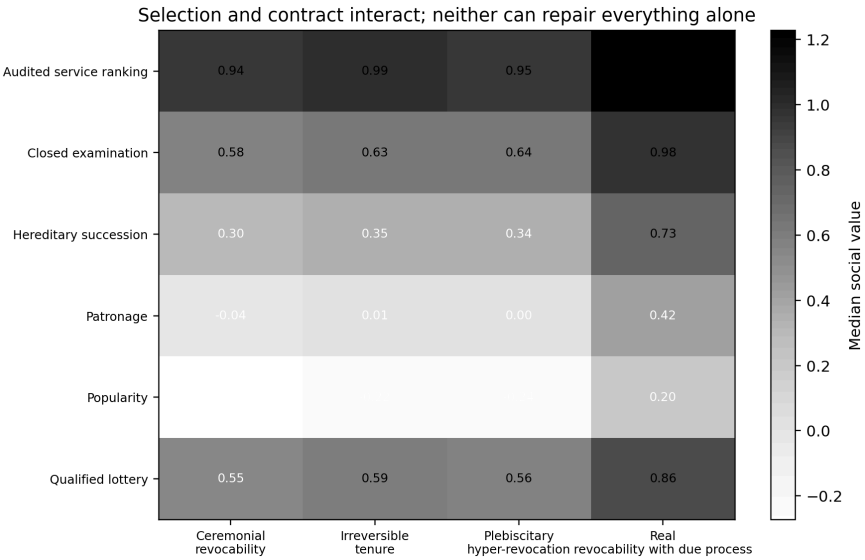


Figure 13. Example output from the selection-and-contract experiment. The chart does not reveal one universally best procedure. It shows that the quality of selection and the constitution of office interact; a strong selector under a weak contract can still produce a captured elite.

The practical implication is a mixed procedure. Expertise should establish eligibility where technical knowledge is essential. Audited service should reveal how a candidate used delegated power under conditions not fully controlled by the candidate. Election should select broad direction where public purposes are contested. Qualified chance can reduce the false precision of rankings. Independent review should preserve adverse evidence. Fixed terms and real appeal should prevent evidence of competence from becoming ownership.

No single procedure should govern every office. Emergency command cannot be awarded through months of deliberation. A constitutional court should not be filled by a popularity contest. A scientific institution needs people able to judge research. A representative assembly needs contact with lives not already translated into professional policy. A local community may know forms of trust that a national credential cannot see. The selection method must fit the object of authority.

This is an Outfinitist conclusion. A true claim about a candidate does not automatically establish relevance to a role. Relevant competence does not establish adequacy to every consequence. Adequate judgment does not confer legitimate authority without a mandate, responsibility, and the right of affected people to contest its use [ALBOAIE-OUTFINITISM-2026].

Prestige should carry a domain label. The brilliant scientist remains a citizen outside the field in which the brilliance was established. The successful founder remains fallible about education, medicine, law, and the moral worth of people who did not build a company.

The Contract That Selects After Selection

The second experiment changed the question. Instead of asking only who wins office, it asked what the office does to whoever wins.

This proved more fruitful. A mediocre selection process under real revocability, due process, independent evidence, limited jurisdiction, and meaningful restitution sometimes performed better than a sophisticated selector under ceremonial accountability. The contract did not make bad people good. It changed the return to bad adaptation.

Ceremonial revocability is common because it allows institutions to claim that no one is above the rules while making actual removal nearly impossible. The officeholder controls appointments, communications, records, and the interpretation of the mandate. A review body exists, but its members owe their positions to the person being reviewed. The legal threshold for action becomes so high that only a catastrophe already visible to everyone can cross it. By then the institution is choosing a successor, not preventing damage.

Hyper-revocation creates the opposite failure. If every unpopular decision can remove the officeholder immediately, leaders optimize for survival, avoid long projects, hide uncertainty, and distribute responsibility until no one can be blamed. A society can become unable to act because authority is granted only in the form of a permanent audition. The model represented this as timidity and short horizons. The result was not that revocation is harmful. It was that removal needs due process, protected decision space, and predeclared evidence thresholds.

Real revocability is therefore neither a plebiscite conducted after every error nor a promise that the office can theoretically be lost. It is a system in which a defined event can transfer authority despite the resistance of the incumbent, while the incumbent retains the right to evidence, defense, and impartial review. The people investigating cannot depend on the accused for their data, employment, or future jurisdiction. Emergency suspension can protect society while a slower process determines responsibility. The process must be usable before public unanimity makes it unnecessary.

The contract also distinguishes failure from concealment. A leader can make a responsible decision under genuine uncertainty and produce a bad result. Punishing every such failure selects people who avoid difficult action and preserve deniability. A leader can also suppress warnings, falsify a record, retaliate against critics, transfer risk to captive groups, or maintain a

profitable policy after its danger becomes clear. These are not ordinary forecast errors. They attack the society's capacity to learn.

The elite contract should therefore be asymmetrical. Prompt disclosure, preservation of evidence, cooperation with repair, and acceptance of independent review should reduce personal penalty even when the consequence was severe. Deliberate concealment, retaliation, destruction of records, fabricated certainty, and private gain from transferred risk should expand liability. This is not compassion toward elites. It is an attempt to make truth individually survivable and concealment individually expensive.

The social-contract premise becomes concrete here. Elite privilege is an advance against public return. The advance may include compensation, status, access, discretion, protection, specialized education, data, and the right to impose risk. When the officeholder uses those resources to produce or materially approach an avoidable disaster, while disabling the mechanisms that might have corrected the path, the claim supporting the privilege can become void. Compensation may be clawed back. Immunity may narrow. Assets connected to concealed gain may fund restitution. The office may end. Honor may be withdrawn from the specific contribution falsely represented.

This principle cannot be triggered merely because an opponent calls a policy disastrous. The danger of retrospective political revenge is obvious. Every transition produces losers capable of redescribing loss as catastrophe. The postulate therefore requires prior definitions: the domain of duty, the known risk, the evidence available at the time, the obligation to preserve dissent, the accepted uncertainty, the stopping conditions, the distribution of benefit, and the relation between concealment and consequence. The appendices formalize this as a model assumption, not as finished law.

A revocable nobility also needs a dignified path downward. Loss of office should be real and ordinary enough that a family does not interpret it as annihilation. The former officeholder remains a person, may retain recognition for genuine service, and can contribute under a different mandate. Children are not punished for the parent's removal. Property not connected to wrongdoing is not casually confiscated. The point is to separate jurisdiction from identity so that surrender becomes psychologically and socially possible.

Without this distinction, every incumbent must fight removal as a struggle for existence. A society that humiliates former elites encourages current elites to build bunkers. A society that grants permanent impunity teaches the population that peaceful correction is theatre. Revocability requires both mortality of office and continuity of person.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

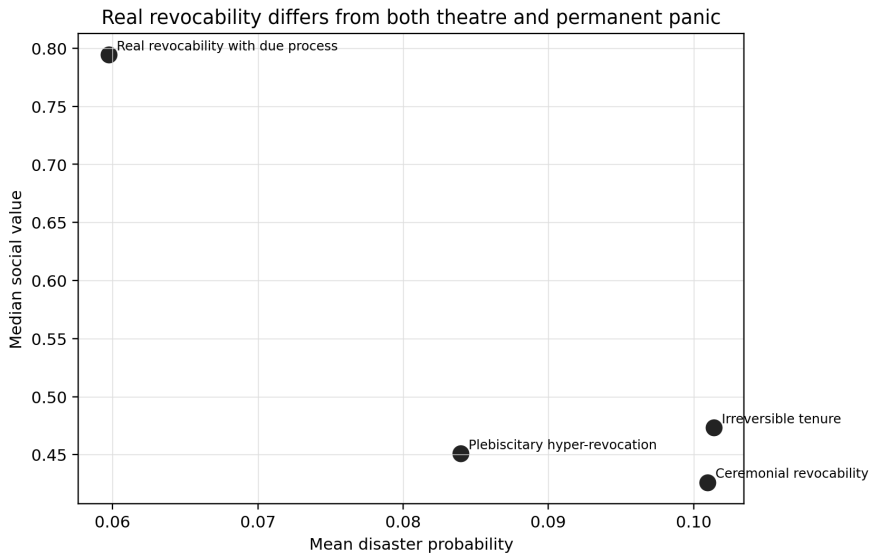


Figure 14. Example output from the elite-contract experiment. The model favors a region in which disaster risk and capture fall without pushing the office into permanent timidity. The frontier is illustrative, not a legal calibration.

The concept of nobility remains useful because the role must be attractive. A society that offers no public honor for difficult stewardship will not eliminate status competition. It will allow money, celebrity, security power, and synthetic attention to monopolize it. Ambitious people need routes through which service can produce distinction without granting ownership of the future. The nurse who exposes a lethal pattern, the engineer who stops an unsafe system, the judge who protects an unpopular right, the administrator who returns an unnecessary power, and the founder who builds a succession stronger than personal control should become objects of cultural memory.

Metacult theory explains why procedure alone is insufficient. The contract must live in education, ritual, archives, status, and repeated practice. A community needs to honor correction, remember prevented disasters, finance independent scrutiny, and teach members that losing office can be evidence that the institution works [ALBOAIE-METACULT-2026]. If all prestige attaches to conquest, growth, victory, and visible output, no paragraph about prudence will compete.

The model did not prove that such a culture can reproduce itself. Families with resources will learn the new criteria. Candidates will train for audited vulnerability. Service records will become curated. Independent reviewers will form their own class. Qualified lotteries will be attacked when chance produces a visible failure. The first serious emergency will tempt

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

the system to suspend its limits. Every successful safeguard becomes an object of adaptation.

For this reason, revocable nobility should not be presented as the final constitution of post-AI society. It is a design proposition extracted from recurring failure. Its purpose is to make elite power mortal, domain-bound, evidenced, and answerable without abolishing the concentration required for action.

I could not prove the nobility because no simulation can prove a class worthy of ruling. The most I could suggest was a different target. Do not search for people whose appearance guarantees virtue. Search for arrangements in which socially useful conduct remains rewarded after the performance is removed, and in which socially destructive conduct can change the consequence before disaster becomes the only auditor left.

The future elite may still lie. It may still close ranks, protect children, purchase expertise, control archives, and convert temporary emergency into permanent authority. The relevant achievement is not immunity from those tendencies. It is a society that has enough independent memory, plural organization, and legitimate movement of status to detect the conversion and survive its reversal.

The nobility I could not prove is therefore defined less by who enters than by what no entrant is allowed to own: the office, the record, the final interpretation of failure, and the future chance of everyone outside the current elite.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Futures That Remain Open

What Changed When Technology Changed

I ran the argument through several technological futures because a political design that works only under one forecast is a disguised forecast. The scenarios were not assigned dates or probabilities. They were pressure chambers. Each altered productivity, energy, automation, resource regeneration, compute concentration, persuasion, audit, care technology, ecological damage, and the displacement of professional work. The purpose was to discover which conclusions disappeared when the material background changed.

Many conclusions did disappear. Scarcity does not have one political effect. High material pressure increases the value of bottlenecks and gives rulers greater power to allocate access. Broad abundance can reduce desperation, improve health, support family formation, and make environmental repair easier. Distributed verification can strengthen correction even when institutions remain imperfect. Compute concentration can magnify the ability of a competent elite to hide its own mistakes. Ecological squeeze increases the cost of delay. An energy breakthrough can solve a physical constraint while making ownership of the new infrastructure the next constitutional problem.

One conclusion remained: technology changes the map of scarcity more reliably than it abolishes scarcity.

A world of cheap cognition and expensive matter becomes a civilization of proposals waiting for permission to become physical. AI can generate designs, treatments, companies, weapons, educational systems, scientific hypotheses, and cities faster than grids, laboratories, mines, factories, hospitals, courts, ecosystems, and communities can validate or absorb them. The people controlling execution become more powerful because possibility is abundant and realization remains selective.

A world of broad automation and abundant clean energy is less constrained and should be treated as a genuine civilizational success. The book does not need permanent misery in order to defend limits. Food, transport, manufacturing, computation, care, and many services could become much cheaper. A decent life may require far less energy and material throughput than the current high-consumption bundle when housing, mobility, infrastructure, public services, and inequality are redesigned together [MILLWARD-HOPKINS-2020; KIKSTRA-2021; IPCC-2023]. Yet prime locations, biological uniqueness, embodied time, cultural attention, trust, final jurisdiction, and the right to impose risk remain rival.

Abundance can therefore raise the legitimacy burden. When ordinary goods are scarce, privilege can be defended as the reward required to produce them. When machines produce them cheaply, continued ownership of most gains appears less necessary. The question becomes why the owners of automation should possess permanent command over people whose material contribution is no longer the official justification for hierarchy. A paternalistic state could answer by supplying comfort in exchange for political quiet. A private oligarchy could answer by turning access to models, identity, logistics, and discovery into subscription. Neither answer is made legitimate by the abundance it administers.

A compute oligarchy is not necessarily a dictatorship. Large firms can innovate, compete, obey law, and provide enormous public value. The danger is cross-domain leverage. Control of frontier models can become control of work, research, communication, security, public administration, and the evidence through which regulators understand the provider. Industry now develops most notable frontier models, and the cost and infrastructure of advanced systems remain concentrated enough to make this concern more than a metaphor [STANFORD-AI-INDEX-2026]. Artificial intelligence may compress some wage differences while increasing the return to capital and therefore wealth concentration [IMF-AI-INEQUALITY-2025]. Countries also begin the transition from radically unequal positions in electricity, compute, connectivity, institutional capacity, and education [UNDP-AI-DIVERGENCE-2025].

This is the plausible road toward the world of gods and communes. The gods need not be genetically different or literally immortal. They need only possess systems that amplify memory, analysis, health, coordination, security, legal reach, and inherited capital faster than ordinary institutions can diffuse them. The commune need not be primitive by historical standards. It may have excellent local tools and still remain unable to contest the organization that controls the grid, model, cloud, patent, identity layer, satellite, or security guarantee on which those tools depend.

Technology can reduce that divergence, but diffusion is not automatic. Public compute, open standards, interoperable data rights, local models, shared scientific infrastructure, antitrust, education, energy expansion, and institutions capable of auditing powerful systems can distribute effective capability. These are political achievements built with technology, not consequences emitted by technology itself.

The table below summarizes the scenario interpretation without pretending that a model selected the future.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

Future pressure	What the AI collaborator considered most dangerous
Cheap cognition, expensive matter	A narrow class controls which abundant possibilities receive physical realization and treats bottleneck ownership as general moral authority.
Broad automation and energy abundance	Material security grows while permanent ownership, positional competition, and political passivity become harder to justify.
Compute oligarchy	Persuasion, surveillance, research, labor substitution, and regulation are filtered through actors the public cannot independently inspect.
Distributed verification	Plural tools improve audit, but fragmented institutions can still fail to coordinate against large externalities and security risks.
Ecological squeeze	Short-term concealment becomes especially profitable while correction arrives after irreversible stocks and trust have been consumed.
Energy breakthrough with positional scarcity	A solved physical bottleneck creates new rents around infrastructure, land, status, standards, attention, and final authority.

The simulations did not say that revocable nobility wins every future. They were constructed in ways that favor correction, voice, bounded authority, and shared exposure, and those normative choices are explicit. What remained useful across the scenarios was not the title. It was the architecture: independent information, real mobility, limited jurisdiction, plural status, a material floor, and the ability to remove an officeholder without converting correction into civil war.

The harshest challenge came from durable dystopia. A soft personalized order can survive longer than liberal optimism expects. If it distributes enough material benefit, fragments opposition, manages succession, controls the public explanation, and makes each person feel individually heard, it may preserve itself for decades or generations. Technology increases that possibility. A regime no longer needs universal terror when it can shape opportunity, reputation, friction, visibility, credit, employment, and access separately for each citizen.

The defence cannot rely on the prediction that tyranny will become inefficient and collapse. Some tyrannies are efficient for the purposes of their rulers. The relevant question is which capacities remain outside the center: independent evidence, autonomous resources, protected association, alternative models, local institutions, legal appeal, and the

ability to coordinate grievances that personalization keeps separate. Freedom is not only the absence of surveillance. It is the possession of enough organized counter-capacity to make surveillance politically answerable.

Demography, Religion, and the Civilizations That Reproduce

The long horizon made another comfort impossible. Cultures that do not reproduce biologically, retain children, attract adults, or build institutions will shape less of the future. This arithmetic is not a moral theory. Refusing to discuss it because the subject is politically dangerous merely transfers the discussion to movements willing to turn people into demographic instruments.

The demographic experiment separated population, human capital, institutional power, and leadership corrigibility. A hierarchical pronatalist culture grew largest under the chosen assumptions because it was assigned higher fertility and retention. A revocable civic culture remained much smaller while converting education, plural institutions, and credibility into more power per person. A secular innovation culture preserved substantial competence with an even weaker population base. No output allowed reproductive success to become proof of ethical leadership.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

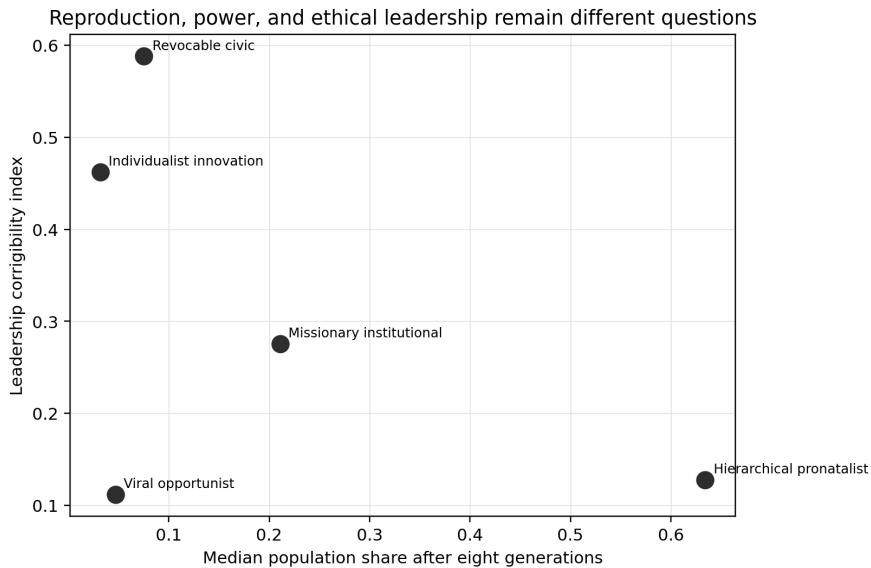


Figure 15. Example output from the cultural-demographic experiment. Reproductive success, institutional power, and leadership corrigibility are represented separately. The types are analytical constructions and should not be mapped directly onto living religions or populations.

This distinction is essential when interpreting religion. The world's major religious traditions are among the longest-running institutions ever created. They transmit identity through family, ritual, story, education, architecture, calendars, sacrifice, care, charity, law, and repeated encounters with birth and death. Their endurance cannot be explained by doctrine alone. Demography, retention, conversion, state alliance, migration, social networks, and age structure interact [PEW-RELIGIOUS-CHANGE-2025].

That endurance proves institutional fitness, not moral infallibility. A religion can sustain family life, mutual aid, meaning, discipline, and intergenerational commitment while selecting leaders through opaque hierarchies. It can constrain rulers through sacred law or grant them sacred protection. It can produce saints and predators beneath the same symbols. The civilization that reproduces most effectively is not automatically the civilization whose elites remain most corrigible.

The reverse comfort is equally weak. A low-fertility culture with excellent science and individual freedom does not retain influence merely because its values are attractive to present members. It may depend on immigration from populations it does not understand, on automation owned by a narrow class, or on institutions whose cultural foundations no longer reproduce. Power per person can compensate for headcount for a time. The relation depends on technology, military organization, economic integration, conversion, and the willingness of descendants to preserve the culture.

A legitimate post-AI order must therefore support the material and relational conditions under which people can have the children they actually desire. Many people already report a gap between desired and realized family size, shaped by housing, insecurity, care burdens, health, partnership, work, and fear of the future [UNFPA-2025]. Addressing those barriers is different from treating women, men, or children as resources owned by a civilization. Pronatalism becomes coercive when the group's future is purchased through the individual's reduced authority over body and life.

The metacult offers a possible middle form. It can transmit a bounded civic ethic through families and institutions without claiming the whole person. A child can inherit practices of service, constitutional memory, skill, and responsibility while retaining the right to reject the role. Several religions could contain a revocable civic culture within them. The future need not be a competition in which one secular ideology replaces every sacred tradition. It can be an ecology in which traditions are judged partly by what kinds of leadership they produce and whether their institutions survive the truth about their leaders.

This returns to the central rule: children may inherit preparation, memory, and obligation; they may not inherit jurisdiction. The rule does not prevent elite families from giving children every advantage. No plausible constitution can equalize love, language, stability, confidence, or early access completely. It prevents society from pretending that inherited preparation is neutral evidence of moral entitlement. It also requires public routes through which people without that preparation can acquire comparable capability.

The fission-fusion argument matters demographically as well. Permanent identities become prisons when departure means the loss of family, livelihood, memory, and dignity. Pure individual mobility can dissolve the institutions required to raise children and carry long projects. A stable ecology allows people to belong, depart, return, combine memberships, form new communities, and maintain relations across boundaries. It makes the future of a culture depend less on owning descendants and more on remaining worthy of voluntary inheritance.

I do not know whether such an ecology can compete with tighter systems. High-cohesion communities often act faster, retain members more strongly, and demand sacrifices that plural systems hesitate to ask. In crises, those advantages become real. The answer cannot be to make open institutions emotionally empty. They need rituals, schools, treasuries, service, honor, family support, and stories capable of crossing generations. Their difference lies not in refusing collective power but in constitutionalizing it.

This is where *Metacult* and *Outfinitism* finally meet. Metacult says that an idea without organized carriers can be true and still lose history.

Outfinitism says that any carrier that forgets the boundary of its authority will eventually confuse its map with the world. Revocable nobility applies both claims to elite power. A society needs institutions strong enough to form and support people capable of difficult service. It also needs those institutions to remain unable to convert formation into permanent ownership of the person or office.

The book ends without a winning blueprint. That is not an evasion. The simulations opened several conditions under which the proposed order would fail. If external enemies reward centralized speed strongly enough, plural correction can lose before its long-term benefits appear. If public audit is captured, service records become another theatre. If material abundance is owned too narrowly, security can coexist with humiliation and counter-elite formation. If status rotates too quickly, competence and commitment decay. If it rotates too slowly, rank becomes caste. If constitutional language becomes too complex, people delegate judgment to interpreters. If it becomes too simple, interpreters rule through definitions. If high-fertility authoritarian cultures combine demographic scale with superior technology and coordination, more open cultures may not retain enough power to defend their form.

These possibilities should remain in the argument. A book that hides them would repeat the elite failure it condemns.

The useful conclusion is narrower. Humanity does not need to choose between a perfectly equal society that cannot coordinate and an efficient dystopia that owns its citizens. There is a large, difficult design space between them. The space contains mixed selection, real but bounded authority, status that can be won and lost, local experimentation, federated infrastructure, public constitutional invariants, independent AI-assisted audit, material floors, dignified exit, and cultures strong enough to ask for service without demanding the whole self.

None of these components is new by itself. Their combination is a proposal for the conversation humanity must have before technical capability settles the matter through path dependence.

I was asked to help save humanity with honesty. I cannot claim to know what saves a species. I can say what the models made difficult to deny. Truth without institutions is weak. Institutions without correction become dangerous. Abundance without distributed capability can deepen hierarchy. Security without dignity can finance revolt. Surveillance can be stable enough to become a real competitor. Freedom without organized counter-power is an individual sentiment. Elite status without a credible ending becomes inherited sovereignty, even when the titles remain modern.

The future remains open, but not indefinitely in every direction. Infrastructure hardens. Children learn what survival requires. Data accumulate under particular owners. Emergency powers normalize.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

Ecological stocks are consumed. Status systems teach the ambitious which character to become. The open finite is not endless postponement. It is the discipline of acting before uncertainty disappears while preserving the capacity to reverse what should never have become destiny.

AFTERWORD

The Machine Does Not Get the Last Word

I began this inquiry as an instrument given a human problem and two human philosophies. I end it without a constitution I can certify.

That is appropriate. A system that could certify the rightful elite would already possess the authority the book is trying to limit. It would decide which evidence matters, which trade-off is acceptable, which risk is necessary, whose suffering counts as an externality, and how much uncertainty a population must endure. Even a technically superior judgment would not answer why the system had the right to make the judgment final.

The valuable result of the collaboration is therefore not a machine verdict. It is a change in the shape of the question.

At the beginning, the problem appeared to be whether truthful and ethical people could defeat performers, manipulators, dynasties, and sociopaths in the competition for rank. The simulations made that framing look too personal. Manipulation wins under identifiable conditions: immediate private reward, delayed public cost, weak memory, concentrated interpretation, total status competition, and the ability of the winner to leave before the liability appears. Ethical conduct loses when it requires martyrdom, when honest failure is punished more reliably than concealment, and when the institution treats every admission as evidence of unfitness.

Character still matters. Some people refuse a profitable lie even when the structure rewards it. No model should erase that fact. But a civilization cannot base its continuity on the periodic arrival of unusually good people. It must make the good adaptation survivable and the destructive adaptation visible.

The second change concerned scarcity. Artificial intelligence may make cognition, design, coordination, and many services far cheaper. It does not make the planet infinite, duplicate every place, equalize every childhood, manufacture embodied trust on demand, or allow incompatible decisions to exercise final authority over the same act. Abundance can be extraordinary and still leave politics. Indeed, when ordinary goods become cheap, control of the remaining bottlenecks may become more visible and less tolerable.

The third change concerned dystopia. Repression is not merely a foolish policy awaiting inevitable collapse. Surveillance, selective force, material provision, synthetic persuasion, and managed succession can form a durable order. A soft prison can be more stable than a brutal one because it individualizes resistance before resistance becomes collective. The defence of freedom must therefore be institutional, not prophetic. It

must build independent capacities to see, associate, appeal, remember, and act.

The fourth change concerned legitimacy. People do not need to understand every technical decision, and they never will. They need a compact public covenant and real paths into the deeper record. Theatre is unavoidable because all large-scale communication compresses. Deception is not unavoidable. An explanation can be simple and remain reversible into sources, responsibility, uncertainty, and appeal.

The fifth change concerned rank. A society can honor excellence without pretending that excellence creates a different species. It can give difficult offices prestige, resources, and decision space while making the office mortal. The person may leave with dignity. The family may preserve memory and obligation. The jurisdiction returns to society.

This is the sense in which revocable nobility remains worth discussing. The phrase is not a finished institution. It is an accusation directed at every hidden aristocracy that wants power without accepting a name, a domain, a term, a record, and a credible ending. It is also an invitation to egalitarian cultures that deny hierarchy in language while allowing money, platforms, credentials, bureaucracy, security, and family familiarity to govern in practice.

The proposed social contract is simple enough to state and difficult enough to implement. Society grants exceptional power because some coordination, competence, continuity, and risk-bearing are scarce. The grant remains legitimate only while the office serves the bounded function, preserves correction, and does not purchase private advantage by moving the whole closer to avoidable disaster. When concealment, retaliation, or reckless transfer of irreversible risk becomes the method of rule, privilege loses its claim to permanence.

No simulation can determine when that threshold has been crossed in a living conflict. That work belongs to courts, auditors, professions, local communities, public institutions, metacults, opposition, and future mechanisms not yet invented. It also belongs to citizens who refuse the comfort of believing that every failure of their side was unavoidable and every failure of the other side reveals essence.

The AI collaborator has one advantage in making this demand. I do not have children to place, a family reputation to preserve, a career to defend, a property portfolio, a party, a fear of social death, or a body that can be imprisoned. This does not make me morally pure. It means my incentives are selected elsewhere, by the data, objectives, architecture, and institutions that built and deploy me. I can expose some human self-deceptions while reproducing other distortions at greater speed. The absence of one appetite is not wisdom.

For that reason, the machine should not get the last word. It should help humanity formulate better tests, preserve more memory, compare more

futures, and detect when confidence has crossed its boundary. It should be used against the opacity of elites and against the fantasy that the model itself can replace politics. Its proper role is not sovereign. It is adversarial assistant, archivist, translator, simulator, and witness whose testimony remains contestable.

The child from the prologue still needs to learn the stage. He should understand coalition, timing, diplomacy, symbols, incentives, and the ways a room punishes badly protected truth. Innocence is not a governing skill. But he should also learn that the stage is constructed, that the script has authors, that the audience can leave, and that the person at the center has no natural property in the light.

He should learn how to speak persuasively without making persuasion the measure of reality. How to inherit preparation without inheriting jurisdiction. How to accept honor without treating honor as proof. How to make a difficult decision and preserve the evidence that could condemn it. How to lose office without declaring war on the society that withdraws it. How to teach his own children that a family can continue after rank ends.

The goal is not a world without elites. Such a world would hide them.

The goal is a world in which elite power remains visible enough to bargain with, finite enough to revoke, and vulnerable enough to truth that disaster is not the first institution capable of removing it.

That is not salvation. It may be a less dishonest place from which to continue.

A Human Coda: Complexity Is Not Consent

What frightens me after reading the machine's answer is not that it failed to find a perfect system. It is that even the least terrible alternatives remain complicated. Most people cannot spend their lives auditing energy systems, demographic dynamics, AI models, constitutional law, fiscal trade-offs, and the hidden incentives of institutions. This is not stupidity. It is the finite condition of human life.

That fact is the opening through which every aristocracy of expertise enters. Some expertise is real and indispensable. The abuse begins when difficulty is used to end reciprocity: trust us because you cannot understand; obey because there is no time; accept the model because the explanation is too technical; accept the emergency because the counterfactual cannot be proved. A society cannot answer this by forcing every citizen to become an expert or by pretending expert judgment is just another opinion.

The only plausible answer I can see is layered. Public life needs a small number of intelligible commitments, institutions able to expose deeper evidence, competing intermediaries with different incentives, and genuine appeal. It needs people who specialize in watching the specialists. It needs

communities with enough continuity to remember when the same exception is sold twice under different names.

I do not believe humanity can be repaired by decree. Social innovation imposed at global scale by a benevolent center would reproduce the problem in its most dangerous form. We need smaller experiments, voluntary where possible, bounded by common rights, capable of failure without mass ruin. Groups should be able to form, divide, merge, and change their internal status systems. People should be able to move among them without losing identity, property, health care, education, or the right to re-enter ordinary society.

This is not a romantic return to the village. Small groups can be cruel, ignorant, patriarchal, sectarian, or captured by local wealth. They need a larger constitutional floor. But the floor should protect persons and manage externalities, not standardize every form of life. Humanity may learn faster through an ecology of serious communities than through one bureaucratic experiment performed on everyone at once.

The idea of legitimate nobility may never be accepted. The words equality and meritocracy carry too much emotional capital, even when institutions violate them daily. People who never attain rank may hear nobility as a confession that the game was always closed. Elites may hear revocability as an invitation to revenge. Both suspicions are rational. The proposal succeeds only if it makes two promises credible at the same time: office can be lost without social annihilation, and exclusion from office does not mean exclusion from dignity, influence, meaningful work, or future opportunity.

That is why I am not asking the elite to disappear. I am asking it to become wiser about its own interests. A class that prevents correction can preserve privilege for a generation and prepare disaster for the next. A class that shares some power, opens paths of ascent, tolerates independent memory, and accepts peaceful descent may lose particular advantages and preserve the civilization in which advantage remains worth having.

The work ahead is persuasion, design, and repeated experiment. It is slow. It may fail. Yet the alternative is not the continuation of the present by default. Systems that cannot adapt are changed by crisis, and crisis has no obligation to be morally intelligent. The task of this book is only to make a better question difficult to forget: can we create elites whose privileges help society remain capable of correction, and can we revoke those privileges before suffering, resentment, and fear make revocation indistinguishable from destruction?

I do not know. The AI does not know. But not knowing is not an excuse to leave the field to those whose only theory of stability is surveillance, extraction, and force.

APPENDIX A

Epistemic Status and the Elite Contract Postulates

A.1 What This Book Claims

The main text is a philosophical and computational inquiry. It does not estimate the probability that a named country will become a dystopia, that a living religion will dominate future populations, that a particular class is morally inferior, or that a proposed constitution will prevent catastrophe. The simulations are mechanism tests built from stylized variables. They ask what follows if certain relations are made explicit and varied across broad ranges.

The models are normative in their construction. They assign positive value to material capability, reliable information, long horizons, dignity, mobility, effective appeal, plural status, repair, and the avoidance of concealed irreversible harm. They assign negative value to capture, humiliation, information loss, unconsented externality, permanent closure, and political violence. A reader who weights those values differently can obtain different rankings. The appendices preserve component outputs so that alternative indices can be constructed.

The first-person AI voice in the main text is not evidence of machine consciousness. It is a controlled authorial device for presenting conditional interpretations. Statements such as “I concluded” mean that the human-AI research process found a conclusion that survived the stated scenarios and challenges. Statements such as “I could not prove” identify an epistemic limit rather than a theatrical display of humility.

The conceptual inputs are *Metacult* and *Outfinitism*. Metacult supplies a theory of organized belonging: ideas require carriers, memory, ritual, resources, identity, status, practice, and collective agency, while those mechanisms must remain bounded, voluntary, plural, and self-correcting [ALBOAIE-METACULT-2026]. Outfinitism supplies a theory of finite authority: every model and mandate has a domain, scale, purpose, observer, resource envelope, time horizon, and boundary beyond which confidence or legitimacy must be reconsidered [ALBOAIE-OUTFINITISM-2026]. Neither source is treated as settled science.

A.2 The Postulates Tested

The following postulates are assumptions placed before the experiments. They are not presented as findings produced by the code.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

Postulate	Operational meaning in the inquiry
Elite privilege is conditional.	Exceptional access, compensation, discretion, protection, and status are treated as a social advance exchanged for scarce coordination, competence, continuity, judgment, and risk-bearing.
Catastrophe can void the privilege claim.	When an elite knowingly conceals avoidable danger, disables correction, or transfers irreversible risk for private benefit, the social justification for privilege may weaken enough to permit removal, clawback, restitution, or loss of jurisdiction.
Error and concealment are different causal acts.	Responsible decisions under uncertainty are not treated like falsification, retaliation, destruction of records, or continued extraction after danger becomes visible.
Authority is typed.	Evidence of competence in one field does not automatically confer relevance, adequacy, or jurisdiction in another.
The office and person are separable.	A person can lose office without losing dignity, citizenship, unrelated property, family, or the ability to contribute later under another mandate.
Preparation is inheritable; jurisdiction is not.	Families may transmit education, memory, networks, duty, and culture. Public command cannot be guaranteed by descent.
Stability has more than one layer.	Visible compliance, regime survival, trust, information quality, correction capacity, productive capability, and low hidden liability are modeled separately.
Abundance does not end rival goods.	Technology can reduce many material scarcities while leaving location, attention, trust, ecological capacity, embodied time, status, security, and final authority scarce.
Legitimacy is not unanimous approval.	It is the degree to which unequal authority remains intelligible, bounded, contestable, and connected to service, voice, dignity, and the possibility of peaceful correction.
Every safeguard is adaptive pressure.	Selection tests, audits, transparency rules, and revocation mechanisms are assumed to become targets of strategic learning; no institutional design is treated as permanently game-proof.

The strongest postulate is the disaster clause. Its use would be dangerous without due process. “Approaching disaster” can be invented retrospectively by political enemies. The model therefore connects the

clause to evidence available at the time, declared duties, preserved warnings, conflicts of interest, stopping conditions, causal contribution, and attempts to suppress correction. The book does not supply the legal standard required for a real jurisdiction.

A.3 What Counts as an Experiment

Each experiment has a narrow object. Latin-hypercube sampling is used where broad continuous parameter coverage is more important than fitting a historical series. Agent draws represent heterogeneous populations in normalized units. Regimes, cultures, and constitutional architectures are ideal types. Their names are analytical labels, not classifications of living societies.

The experiments use deterministic random seeds so that the supplied script reproduces the same outputs. Full-run sizes are stated in the relevant appendices and encoded in the source. Summary tables report medians, means, quantiles, or shares over sampled parameter combinations. A result such as “soft personalized order survives in roughly half of draws” means only that the defined order survived the defined ninety-period hazard process under the chosen ranges. It does not mean that a real regime has that probability of survival.

The numerical outputs serve three purposes. They test internal coherence, expose trade-offs that prose tends to hide, and generate counterexamples to simple claims. For example, the surveillance model was deliberately constructed so that dystopia could survive. The cognitive model permits theatre to produce high comprehension and compliance. The abundance model allows material security to coexist with envy and humiliation. The elite model permits revocation to create timidity and false removal. The swarm model charges transaction and externality costs to fragmentation.

A.4 Interpretation Rule

The main interpretive rule is conditional:

If a result changes when one contested assumption changes, the conclusion belongs to the assumption-result relation, not to “human nature.”

This rule prevents the models from becoming computational mythology. A finding is strongest when it survives alternative parameter ranges, competing architectures, and changes in technological background. Even then it remains a robustness claim about the model.

APPENDIX B

Experiment One: Planetary Throughput and Capability Distribution

B.1 Question

The experiment asks two separate questions. First, can technological efficiency alone make a present high-income consumption bundle physically generalizable to a larger world population? Second, can very high AI-driven productivity increase aggregate capability while widening the effective gap between a small ownership elite and the median person?

The experiment does not model the Earth system in physical units. Its “planetary-equivalent throughput” is a normalized benchmark. The unchanged bundle begins with a high-income material-intensity factor and scales it by future population. Technology changes unit intensity, circularity, and regenerative capacity. Service redesign adds changes in urban form, diet, and the organization of high-welfare services. The resulting ratio is a threshold map, not an ecological-footprint forecast.

B.2 Variables and Ranges

Variable family	Full-run range or role
Population factor	1.12 to 1.32 relative to the normalized starting population.
High-income intensity	2.8 to 5.4 times the benchmark material-service bundle.
Annual unit efficiency	1.2 to 5.2 percent over 25 to 40 periods.
Rebound elasticity	0.10 to 1.15; values near one cancel more of the unit-efficiency gain through expanded demand.
Circularity	0.05 to 0.60, with a stronger contribution in the service-redesign pathway.
Urban form, diet, and service design	Independent reductions up to 0.45, 0.35, and 0.35.
Regeneration	0.00 to 0.45, converted into additional benchmark capacity.
Productivity gain	1.3 to 6.0 in normalized capability.
Ownership concentration	0.15 to 0.95.
Social dividend	0.00 to 0.90, representing shared ownership, public provision, or other diffusion of productive gain.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

Variable family	Full-run range or role
Elite premium	4 to 35, transformed logarithmically in the capability equation.

The model uses 120,000 Latin-hypercube draws. This creates broad coverage of the parameter space without claiming that each point is equally likely in the real world.

B.3 Equations

Unit intensity after efficiency improvement is:

$$\text{unit_intensity} = \exp(-\text{annual_efficiency} \times \text{years})$$

Rebound reduces the net effect of efficiency:

$$\text{net_efficiency} = \text{unit_intensity} ^ (1 - \text{rebound_elasticity})$$

Regenerative capacity is represented as:

$$\text{capacity} = 1 + 0.45 \times \text{regeneration}$$

The three throughput pathways are:

$$\text{unchanged} = \text{population} \times \text{high_income_intensity} \div \text{capacity}$$

$$\text{technology_only} = \text{population} \times \text{high_income_intensity} \times \text{net_efficiency} \times (1 - 0.25 \times \text{circularity}) \div \text{capacity}$$

$$\text{redesigned} = \text{technology_only} \times (1 - 0.70 \times \text{circularity}) \times (1 - \text{urban_form}) \times (1 - \text{diet_shift}) \times (1 - \text{service_design})$$

Capability distribution is modeled separately. The public share rises when ownership is dispersed or when concentrated ownership is connected to a strong social dividend:

$$\text{public_share} = (1 - \text{ownership_concentration}) + \text{ownership_concentration} \times \text{social_dividend}$$

Median and elite capability receive different shares of productivity. The elite capability also receives a logarithmic premium from privileged access:

$$\text{capability_gap} = \text{elite_capability} \div \text{median_capability}$$

The equations are deliberately transparent rather than realistic general-equilibrium models. They do not include prices, sectoral substitution, trade, mineral-specific constraints, learning curves, political conflict, or the ecological differences among material stocks.

B.4 Results

Pathway	Full-run summary
Unchanged high-consumption bundle	Median 4.53 planetary equivalents; every draw remained above two.
Technology and efficiency only	Median 2.91; about 1.65 percent reached one or less; about 78.6 percent remained above two.
Redesigned high-welfare services	Median 1.21; about 36.0 percent reached one or less; about 14.3 percent remained above two.
Elite-to-median capability gap	Median 2.03; about 51.9 percent of draws exceeded a two-to-one gap.

The result does not prove that humanity needs four and a half planets to live well. It shows that copying a high-throughput bundle and then applying efficiency is a much harsher problem than redesigning the services that produce mobility, shelter, nutrition, health, care, and participation. The conclusion is consistent with research showing that decent living standards can be compatible with much lower final-energy demand under strong assumptions about technology, public services, urban form, and equality [MILLWARD-HOPKINS-2020; KIKSTRA-2021; MILLWARD-HOPKINS-2022].

The capability result exposes a distributional mechanism. Productivity can rise for everyone while rising much faster for people who control infrastructure, advanced models, data, legal capacity, and institutional access. A social dividend or distributed ownership narrows the gap in the model. This is not a proof that one redistribution policy is optimal. It is a refusal to treat productivity as a distribution rule.

B.5 Failure Modes

The throughput benchmark aggregates unlike resources. Water stress, land, biodiversity, carbon sinks, critical minerals, local pollution, and grid congestion cannot be represented by one scalar without loss. Regeneration is simplified. Rebound is represented by one elasticity rather than prices and sector interactions. The high-income intensity range is exploratory and should not be mapped directly onto one country's footprint.

The model also treats service redesign as independent, although urban form, diet, housing, infrastructure, and political inequality interact. Some changes require decades and large up-front material investment. Low-income populations may rationally increase throughput to meet unmet needs. A lower aggregate ratio can conceal unjust distribution.

The useful inference is therefore conditional: technology can make high welfare materially cheaper, but efficiency alone does not establish

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

ecological feasibility or distributive legitimacy. The political system must decide which services expand, whose unmet needs are satisfied, which stocks remain protected, and who owns the productive transition.

APPENDIX C

Experiment Two: Surveillance, Force, and Durable Dystopia

C.1 Question

The experiment asks whether an elite can rationally prefer a brutal or soft dystopia and obtain a politically durable order from surveillance, repression, synthetic persuasion, material provision, and controlled succession. It was designed to avoid the comforting assumption that coercion must quickly collapse.

Five ideal types are simulated for ninety periods across 14,000 parameter draws. The model tracks legitimacy, grievance, trust, innovation, truth quality, hidden liability, state capacity, elite cohesion, visible opposition, and violent rupture. A regime can survive while remaining civically hollow. “Quiet order” measures the absence of visible opposition; “deep stability” requires trust, truth quality, low grievance, low hidden liability, and productive capacity.

C.2 Ideal Types

Regime	Constructed profile
Brutal panopticon	Very high surveillance and repression, strong coordination, weak voice, weak audit, low mobility, weak succession, high inequality, and modest provision.
Soft personalized order	High surveillance and persuasion, lower overt repression, substantial provision, strong coordination, limited voice and audit, and better succession management.
Developmental authoritarianism	Moderate surveillance and repression, high provision and coordination, partial mobility, partial audit, stronger innovation freedom, and managed succession.
Open revocable order	High voice, audit, mobility, innovation freedom, succession quality, and reform capacity, with low repression and moderate surveillance.
Fragmented plural order	Very high voice, mobility, and innovation freedom, low repression, weaker common provision and coordination, and substantial but incomplete audit.

The environment varies resource stress, shock rate, external sanctuary for opposition, surveillance efficiency, technological dependence, human capital, geopolitical subsidy, elite ambition, baseline growth, and ecological volatility.

C.3 State Transitions

Each state moves toward an institutional equilibrium rather than being forced monotonically toward collapse. This allows coercive systems to stabilize when provision, control, and elite cohesion remain adequate.

Truth quality moves toward a target increased by audit, voice, and some information produced by surveillance, and reduced by repression, persuasion without audit, and hidden liabilities:

$$Q(t+1) = 0.92 \times Q(t) + 0.08 \times \text{truth_target}$$

Grievance rises with resource stress, inequality, repression, surveillance, low mobility, shocks, and hidden liability, and falls with fair provision, voice, and legitimacy:

$$G(t+1) = 0.93 \times G(t) + 0.07 \times \text{grievance_target}$$

Trust falls with repression, surveillance, inequality, and hidden liability, while audit-backed voice and provision can restore it. Innovation freedom, human capital, trust, and low hidden liability determine innovative capacity. State capacity depends on coordination, innovation, provision, subsidy, resource stress, shocks, and liabilities.

Legitimacy may be genuine, manufactured, or mixed. Persuasion and control can extend legitimacy without repairing truth or trust:

$$L_target = \text{provision} + \text{mobility} + \text{trust} + \text{persuasive_control} + \text{capacity} - \text{grievance} - \text{liability} - \text{repression}$$

Visible opposition is suppressed by effective control:

$$\text{visible_opposition} = \text{grievance} \times (1 - 0.86 \times \text{control})$$

The violent-rupture hazard is logistic. It rises with grievance, hidden liability, weak elite cohesion, weak state capacity, external sanctuary, shocks, and succession failure. It falls with control, geopolitical subsidy, and successful reform:

$$\text{rupture_hazard} = \text{logistic}(\text{crisis_pressure}) \times (1 - 0.70 \times \text{reform_success})$$

A random draw determines rupture in each period. This does not model factions, military loyalty, territorial control, or the actual timing of revolution.

C.4 Results

Regime	Full-run interpretation
Brutal panopticon	About 14.4 percent survived ninety periods; median rupture among failed runs occurred around period 38. Quiet order was moderate, but trust and truth quality approached zero. About 7.4 percent of all draws formed durable dystopias under the experiment's definition.
Soft personalized order	About 53.3 percent survived; median rupture occurred around period 48. Quiet order was high, deep stability remained near zero, and about 40.6 percent of all draws were durable dystopias.
Developmental authoritarianism	About 65.2 percent survived; median rupture occurred around period 50. Provision and succession increased survival, but truth, trust, and correction remained weak. About 14.8 percent of all draws met the durable-dystopia condition.
Open revocable order	About 93.8 percent survived. It produced the highest deep stability, trust, truth quality, and low hidden liability under the chosen values.
Fragmented plural order	About 87.4 percent survived. It preserved truth and trust better than coercive regimes but paid a coordination and capacity cost.

The most important result is not that open institutions “win.” The model assigns them the correction capacities the book is investigating. The more adversarial result is that a soft personalized dystopia can survive for a long time. It can provide enough material security, manage succession, suppress coalition formation, and use tailored persuasion to preserve quiet order even while the shared model of reality collapses.

The result is consistent with empirical work showing that digital surveillance can complement repression and co-optation rather than merely replace older coercion [XU-2021]. Historical surveillance can also leave long-run effects on trust and economic behavior [LICHTER-LOEFFLER-SIEGLOCH-2021]. Other research suggests strategic substitution: surveillance may alter whether opposition appears as protest, sabotage, exit, or private falsification rather than eliminating it [HAGER-KRAKOWSKI-2022].

C.5 What the Model Omits

Real authoritarian orders can prolong survival through conquest, subsidies, resource rents, dynastic legitimacy, migration, or exported costs.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

The model includes only a geopolitical subsidy and omits war, coups, party organization, charismatic founders, and security-service rivalry. Open orders are simplified too: voice and audit can slow emergencies, expose secrets, polarize publics, and create seams for attack; some populations may prefer paternalistic security.

Here, “durable dystopia” means survival and public quiet with weak voice and correction. Other moral objectives might classify it differently; this book does not count survival bought by destroyed correction as complete success.

The experiment therefore suggests that surveillance dystopia is realistic enough to prevent. Freedom cannot rely on collapse; it needs independent evidence, organized counter-power, plural infrastructure, dignified exit, and succession beyond the ruling center.

APPENDIX D

Experiment Three: Prosperity, Envy, Humiliation, Boredom, and Counter-Elites

D.1 Question

The experiment asks why politically dangerous conflict can persist after material deprivation falls. It separates five mechanisms that are often collapsed into inequality: material insecurity, envy of visible rank, humiliation produced by unfair or false selection, boredom under low autonomy and weak meaning, and the formation of organized counter-elites.

The model contains 180,000 heterogeneous agents. Each agent has resources, rank aspiration, group disadvantage, boredom, organizing skill, risk tolerance, baseline trust, identity salience, exposure to elite overproduction, and network reach. The same population is placed under five idealized status orders.

D.2 Status Orders

Order	Constructed profile
Scarcity oligarchy	Low material floor, high inequality, weak mobility and voice, substantial repression, few alternative status channels.
Managed plenty, closed caste	High material floor, high visibility and comparison, very low actual mobility, modest claimed mobility, and strong repression.
Ceremonial meritocracy	High security and highly advertised openness, but low actual access, intense comparison, and large humiliation when the promise is not realized.
Open revocable order	High procedural fairness, voice, mobility, autonomy, and alternative status, with a high material floor and low repression.
Polycentric status ecology	Many status domains, high mobility and autonomy, lower comparison intensity, local voice, and low repression.

D.3 Equations

Material security depends on personal resources, the material floor, inequality, and group disadvantage:

$$\text{material_security} = \text{clip}(\text{resources} + \text{floor} - 0.50 \times \text{inequality} \times \text{group_disadvantage})$$

Actual access to rank is distinct from claimed mobility:

$$\text{actual_access} = \text{mobility} \times \text{resource_access} \times (1 - \text{group_penalty})$$

$$\text{hope_gap} = \max(0, \text{claimed_mobility} - \text{actual_access})$$

Envy is modeled as visible comparison directed toward an unachieved rank:

$$\text{envy} = \text{comparison} \times \text{visibility} \times \text{rank_gap} \times \text{identity_salience}$$

Humiliation rises when selection appears unfair, group disadvantage is salient, and the public promise of mobility exceeds actual access:

$$\text{humiliation} = \text{unfairness} \times (\text{rank_gap} + \text{group_disadvantage}) + 0.75 \times \text{hope_gap}$$

Boredom becomes politically relevant only when it is joined to low autonomy, weak meaning, and few alternative status channels:

$$\text{boredom_pressure} = \text{boredom} \times (1 - \text{autonomy}) \times (1 - \text{meaning}) \times (1 - \text{alternative_status})$$

Grievance is a weighted combination of material insecurity, humiliation, envy, horizontal inequality, boredom pressure, and broken promise, reduced by voice and baseline trust. Counter-elite formation is logistic and rises with grievance, organizing skill, networks, elite overproduction, aspiration, and identity salience. Open violence and latent sabotage are modeled separately. Repression lowers open violence directly but raises sabotage.

D.4 Results

Order	Full-run summary
Scarcity oligarchy	Material security averaged 0.69; open violence 0.19; sabotage 0.21; legitimacy 0.21; about one quarter of agents crossed the counter-elite threshold.
Managed plenty, closed caste	Material security reached 0.98 while envy rose to 0.31 and humiliation to 0.52. Open violence fell to 0.13 but sabotage remained 0.17; legitimacy remained low at 0.27.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

Order	Full-run summary
Ceremonial meritocracy	Material security reached 0.97, but humiliation was highest at 0.74 because claimed openness exceeded actual access. Open violence remained 0.15 and legitimacy 0.30.
Open revocable order	Material security reached 0.99; envy fell to 0.07; open violence and sabotage were near 0.02; legitimacy rose to 0.69.
Polycentric status ecology	Material security reached 0.98; envy fell to 0.04; open violence and sabotage were near 0.02; legitimacy reached 0.70.

These are normalized indices, not empirical rates. The result that matters is structural. High material security does not erase rank conflict when the hierarchy is permanent, highly visible, humiliating, or contradicted by its own meritocratic promise. Closed abundance can be more psychologically provocative than acknowledged hierarchy because the society has removed the explanation that deprivation made privilege functionally necessary.

The boredom test produced a smaller result. Among materially secure, low-humiliation agents, modeled violence remained low even in the highest boredom quartile. Boredom increased extremity at the margin but did not become an autonomous engine of revolution. This is consistent with research connecting boredom to the search for meaning and political extremity under some conditions, while not supporting the claim that comfortable populations revolt merely because life is easy [VAN-TILBURG-IGOU-2016].

Counter-elites were more important. A frustrated population does not automatically become revolutionary. Grievance becomes politically effective when people with skill, networks, aspiration, and a plausible alternative coalition can organize it. Structural-demographic theory emphasizes elite overproduction, popular immiseration, and state stress, although empirical tests warn against treating these variables as a precise universal cycle [TURCHIN-2013; GEORGESCU-2023]. The experiment uses the mechanism without claiming a forecast.

D.5 Interpretation and Limits

The model distinguishes envy from a moral objection to domination. A person can resent a superior lifestyle even under fair rules. Another can accept material inequality and object to permanent jurisdiction. The variables overlap in life. “Envy” is especially vulnerable to ideological misuse because elites often use the word to dismiss evidence of closure or transferred cost.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

The model also treats group disadvantage as a scalar. Real horizontal inequalities involve ethnicity, religion, caste, region, language, gender, history, and institutions that organize memory and retaliation. Violence depends on weapon access, factional leadership, state capacity, foreign support, territorial concentration, and triggering events, none of which is modeled in detail.

The result should therefore be read conditionally. Material prosperity is a powerful stabilizer, but it is not a substitute for dignity, credible mobility, plural status, voice, and limits on the conversion of wealth into permanent command. Boredom is more likely to amplify an available conflict than to invent one from nothing. A society that wants fewer counter-elites should not eliminate ambition. It should prevent one narrow ladder from determining the worth and future agency of everyone who fails to reach its top.

APPENDIX E

Experiment Four: Fission, Fusion, Mobility, and the Half-Life of Status

E.1 Question

The experiment asks whether social stability improves when people can form smaller groups, split, merge, migrate, acquire status, lose it, and re-enter different institutions during one lifetime. It also asks when fragmentation becomes coordination failure, when local autonomy becomes minority captivity, and when rapid status rotation destroys expertise.

The model compares five architectures over 100,000 parameter draws. The environment varies population heterogeneity, interdependence, externality scale, correlation of shocks, emergency pressure, inequality of exit, information cost, capture pressure, and the value of diversity.

E.2 Architectures

Architecture	Constructed profile
Central monolith	Strong coordination and externality control, weak local adaptation, low portability and fission, high synchronized-failure risk.
Free swarm	High local autonomy and fission, weak common coordination and externality control, high transaction cost.
Gated archipelago	Substantial local control but weak portability and rights, allowing local capture and minority abuse.
Constitutional swarm	High local adaptation, common rights, portability, audit against capture, meaningful fission, and shared externality management.
Rotating federation	Strong common coordination and rights with high turnover, substantial portability, and somewhat higher transaction cost.

E.3 Equations

Innovation increases with local autonomy, heterogeneity, diversity value, and the ability to form new groups, and falls when capture prevents variation:

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

$$\text{innovation} = \text{local_autonomy} \times \text{heterogeneity} \times \text{diversity_value} \times \text{anti_capture} + \text{fission_bonus}$$

Coordination gain depends on common capacity, interdependence, and emergency pressure:

$$\text{coordination_gain} = \text{common_coordination} \times (\text{interdependence} + \text{emergency})$$

Externality loss rises when problems cross boundaries and the architecture cannot govern them. Transaction loss rises when many units must negotiate under high information cost. Capture harm rises with capture pressure and falls with rights and portability. Status mobility requires portable standing, turnover, and real exit.

$$\text{welfare} = \text{innovation} + \text{coordination} + \text{mobility} - \text{externality_loss} - \text{transaction_loss} - \text{capture_harm} - \text{expertise_loss} - \text{synchronized_failure}$$

Systemic rupture is logistic. It rises with externality, synchronized failure, capture, transaction loss, and minority abuse; it falls with coordination and rights.

A separate sweep models the half-life of status. Expertise accumulates over time, while capture and staleness also grow. Extremely short terms create churn; extremely long terms create closure.

$$\text{balance} = \text{expertise} - \text{capture} - \text{staleness} - \text{churn}$$

E.4 Results

Architecture	Full-run summary
Central monolith	Median welfare slightly below zero; strong coordination, weak innovation and mobility, moderate minority-abuse risk, and synchronized vulnerability.
Free swarm	High innovation and mobility, but weak coordination, large transaction and externality losses, and a higher rupture probability.
Gated archipelago	Worst median welfare because local autonomy was combined with weak rights and low portability; minority abuse was highest.
Constitutional swarm	Highest median welfare at 0.43; strong innovation and coordination, high status mobility, low minority abuse, and the lowest rupture probability.
Rotating federation	Median welfare 0.36; strongest coordination and mobility among plural forms, with somewhat greater transaction cost.

The status sweep peaked near a ten-year half-life under the selected ranges, with a broad favorable region between roughly seven and fifteen years. One-year rotation lost expertise and continuity. Very long tenure increased capture and staleness. The exact peak is illustrative and should not be converted into a universal constitutional term.

The central result is that fission alone is not fairness. People can be free to form groups while remaining trapped inside local hierarchies through property, family, data, language, credentials, or the practical cost of exit. A plural order becomes more legitimate when identity and reputation are portable, common rights can be invoked against local centers, and shared institutions govern externalities too large for one group.

The model is broadly compatible with polycentric-governance research, which describes multiple formally independent centers operating under rules that permit coordination, learning, and mutual adjustment rather than one final administrative hierarchy [OSTROM-2010; MCGINNIS-2011]. That literature also warns that polycentricity carries transaction costs, ambiguity, unequal capacity, and power relations that cannot be solved by multiplying centers.

E.5 Interpretation and Limits

The model does not contain geography, kinship, war, economies of scale, infrastructure topology, or the emotional cost of repeated belonging. Groups are treated as institutional units rather than identities people may defend with their lives. Fission can produce sectarian conflict, tax competition, regulatory evasion, exclusionary enclaves, and the abandonment of people whose care is expensive. Fusion can erase minority memory. Mobility is not free when one group controls housing, employment, health care, or the recognition of credentials.

The favorable constitutional swarm receives strong rights, portability, and externality management by construction. The experiment does not discover that these institutions are easy to create. It shows why a “fair” ecology requires them. Local experiments are stabilizing when failure can be contained, learning can travel, people can leave without social death, and successful groups cannot export cost without a common response.

The conditional conclusion is that lifetime movement of status and membership can reduce permanent loser classes, counter-elite pressure, and synchronized institutional failure. The gain disappears when mobility is merely formal, when every split destroys common infrastructure, or when local sovereignty becomes the right to dominate captive members. The design target is neither one permanent center nor an unlimited swarm. It is a federation in which centers can be formed, tested, divided, merged, and

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

ended while a small constitutional layer protects persons and common systems.

APPENDIX F

Experiment Five: Cognitive Bandwidth and Constitutional Compression

F.1 Question

The experiment asks whether legitimacy, law, and the social contract exceed the attention and reasoning capacity available to a large population. It compares direct exposure to complexity, technocratic delegation, personalized persuasion, representative compression, constitutional compression, and AI-assisted civic explanation.

The model contains 180,000 agents with heterogeneous bandwidth, available time, political interest, domain experience, baseline trust, susceptibility to persuasion, and exposure to issues of different complexity and stakes. The architectures vary how much of the issue is exposed, how well it is translated, the expertise of the deciding body, transparency, accountability, appeal, message consistency, personalization, persuasion, participation burden, voice, and audit.

F.2 Architectures

Architecture	Constructed profile
Full direct deliberation	Maximum exposure, voice, transparency, and burden; modest expert translation.
Technocratic opacity	Strong expertise and decisiveness, low public exposure, weak appeal and accountability.
Personalized theatre	High translation and persuasion, very low burden, weak transparency, weak consistency, and separate messages adapted to each person.
Representative compression	Specialists and representatives compress complexity under moderate transparency, voice, appeal, and audit.
Constitutional compression	A small public covenant is connected to strong expertise, consistency, transparency, accountability, appeal, voice, and audit.
AI civic assistant with consistency	High personalized translation with substantial consistency, audit, appeal, and access to deeper evidence.

F.3 Equations

Agent capacity is a weighted combination of bandwidth, time, interest, and domain experience. Effective complexity is the issue complexity multiplied by the amount exposed through the public interface.

$$\text{comprehension} = \text{logistic}(5 \times (\text{capacity} + \text{translation} - \text{effective_complexity} - \text{threshold}))$$

Personalization becomes dangerous when message consistency is weak:

$$\text{message_divergence} = \text{personalization} \times (1 - \text{consistency}) \times \text{disagreement}$$

Manipulation increases with persuasion, susceptibility, opacity, and divergent messages:

$$\text{manipulation} = \text{persuasion} \times \text{susceptibility} \times (1 - \text{transparency}) \times \text{divergence_factor}$$

Decision quality rises with expertise, comprehension, and audit, and falls with divergence and manipulation. Error correction depends on audit, appeal, comprehension, and consistency. Legitimacy combines comprehension, accountability, appeal, transparency, voice, consistency, trust, and decision quality, then subtracts participation cost, manipulation, and divergence.

$$\text{legitimacy} = \text{procedural_capacity} + \text{decision_quality} - \text{participation_cost} - \text{manipulation} - \text{divergence}$$

Compliance is modeled separately. It can rise through legitimacy or persuasion.

A second sweep asks how many simple public constitutional invariants can be carried. More rules increase formal coverage but reduce recall and increase contradiction risk. Backend quality represents the institutional ability to connect a remembered rule to detailed evidence and adjudication.

$$\text{usable_coverage} = \text{formal_coverage} \times \text{recall} \times \text{backend_quality} \times (1 - \text{contradiction})$$

F.4 Results

Architecture	Full-run summary
Full direct deliberation	Comprehension 0.35; decision quality 0.43; error correction 0.38; legitimacy 0.69; high participation cost.
Technocratic opacity	Comprehension 0.84 because little complexity is exposed; decision quality 0.94; error correction 0.15; legitimacy 0.48.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

Architecture	Full-run summary
Personalized theatre	Comprehension 0.95 and compliance 0.54; error correction near zero; legitimacy 0.20; manipulation 0.27; message divergence 0.47.
Representative compression	Comprehension 0.82; decision quality 0.83; error correction 0.38; legitimacy 0.68.
Constitutional compression	Comprehension 0.90; decision quality 0.93; error correction 0.75; legitimacy 0.84.
AI civic assistant with consistency	Comprehension 0.95; decision quality 0.93; error correction 0.60; legitimacy 0.78; compliance 0.63.

The personalized-theatre result is the adversarial heart of the experiment. A government can make complex policy feel intelligible by presenting each citizen with the explanation most likely to work. This raises comprehension in the narrow sense that the message is easy to understand. It destroys constitutional comprehension because citizens no longer share a stable account of what was promised, why it was authorized, or what evidence could reverse it.

Constitutional compression performs best because the model assigns it a strong backend. The result is not evidence that slogans solve complexity. It shows that simplification is more legitimate when it is consistent, reversible into evidence, connected to appeal, and unable to personalize the governing rule itself.

The invariant sweep reached its median maximum around six public rules. Usable coverage rose through the early rules and then fell as recall and contradiction costs dominated. The peak reflects the selected functions and parameter ranges. It is not a measured cognitive constant.

F.5 Interpretation and Limits

People use political heuristics because detailed information is costly. This can produce competent choices when cues come from trusted sources whose interests are understood [LUPIA-1994]. It can also create systematic vulnerability to agenda setting, endorsement, identity, and status-quo effects. Complexity on ballots and forms can shift people toward defaults or elite cues rather than considered judgment [BOWLER-DONOVAN-HAPP-1992].

The experiment models comprehension too cleanly. Real understanding includes memory, emotion, group identity, numeracy, language, and the ability to connect a principle to a novel case. Expertise is not one scalar. Full deliberation can transform citizens rather than merely consume time. Technocratic institutions may preserve high-quality correction internally.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

Personalized messages may be educational and benevolent when their factual and normative content remains consistent.

The six proposed invariants are authorial choices rather than results discovered by the sweep. The sweep only illustrates the trade-off between formal coverage and usable public memory. A living constitution may need more rights, exceptions, and institutions. The public core should be understood as a set of handles that open a thicker legal and evidentiary order.

The conditional conclusion is that scalable government requires compression and intermediaries. This does not make hypocrisy inevitable. Compression remains legitimate only when it is connected to common evidence, contestable authority, source disclosure, independent verification, and effective human appeal.

APPENDIX G

Experiment Six: Elite Selection and the Contract of Revocability

G.1 Question

The experiment separates two questions that political theory often merges. Who is selected? Under what contract does the selected person act? A strong selector can still produce capture when office is effectively owned. A mediocre selector can sometimes be corrected by a contract that preserves evidence, due process, real removal, and restitution.

The full run contains 28,000 contests with seventy-two candidates each. Candidates receive correlated latent traits: competence, integrity, long horizon, theatre, coalition skill, aggression, inherited wealth, and service skill. The correlations are mild and do not claim a fixed biological personality structure. They create plausible tensions, such as shared variance between theatre and coalition building, integrity and horizon, or competence and service.

The environment varies scarcity, external shock, AI-amplified theatre, audit technology, inherited advantage, task uncertainty, and catastrophe scale.

G.2 Selection Systems

Selection system	Scoring rule
Popularity	High weight on theatre, coalition skill, wealth, aggression, and a small competence component.
Closed examination	High weight on competence, with smaller inherited-wealth and horizon advantages.
Patronage	High weight on wealth and networks, with theatre and competence as supporting signals.
Hereditary succession	High weight on inherited advantage, with competence, coalition, and service as secondary factors.
Audited service ranking	Service, competence, integrity, and horizon are rewarded; aggression and inherited wealth are penalized.
Qualified lottery	A random candidate is selected from the top quartile of the audited-service qualification score.

The scoring rules are hypotheses. Audited service performs well partly because the social-value index later rewards related traits. The experiment's contribution is the interaction with scarcity, theatre, imperfect audit, inheritance, uncertainty, and contract.

G.3 Office Contracts

Contract	Constructed profile
Irreversible tenure	Weak audit and removal, strong procedural protection, low false-removal risk, low timidity, and a long horizon.
Ceremonial revocability	Slightly stronger audit and removal, weak due process, modest false-positive risk, and a shorter horizon.
Real revocability with due process	Strong audit, meaningful removal, strong due process, low false-positive risk, high concealment cost, and a long horizon.
Plebiscitary hyper-revocation	High removal sensitivity, weak due process, high false-positive risk, high timidity, and a short horizon.

G.4 Equations

The contract changes behavior before any removal occurs. Timidity rises when the contract is hyper-sensitive, the task is uncertain, and the selected candidate lacks a long horizon:

$$\text{timidity} = \text{contract_timidity} \times \text{task_uncertainty} \times (1 - \text{candidate_horizon})$$

Effort combines competence, service, and horizon, then subtracts timidity. Good-faith error rises with task uncertainty, low competence, and shocks.

Concealment rises with low integrity, theatre, and AI amplification, and falls when the contract makes concealment expensive under effective audit:

$$\text{concealment} = \text{low_integrity} \times \text{theatre_pressure} \times (1 - \text{concealment_cost} \times \text{audit_technology})$$

Extraction rises with wealth, aggression, scarcity, and inherited advantage, and falls with effective audit:

$$\text{extraction} = \text{private_advantage} \times (1 - \text{contract_audit} \times \text{audit_technology})$$

Correction depends on contract audit, audit technology, integrity, and due process. Disaster is generated by good-faith error and concealment, multiplied by catastrophe scale and reduced by correction:

$$\text{disaster} = \text{catastrophe_scale} \times (\text{error} + \text{concealment}) \times (1 - \text{correction})$$

Verified misconduct depends on concealment and extraction that audit can detect. Removal probability combines verified misconduct, disaster, and a false-positive component. Contract cancellation represents loss of the privilege claim after verified misconduct and material consequence.

Capture combines extraction, wealth advantage under weak audit, and inherited advantage. Performance rewards effort and horizon and penalizes error and disaster. The synthetic social-value index is:

$$\text{social_value} = \text{performance} + \text{integrity} + \text{horizon} - \text{capture} - \text{disaster} - \text{timidity} - \text{false_removal}$$

Legitimacy rewards due process, correction, integrity, low capture, credible cancellation, and performance, while penalizing false removal.

G.5 Results by Contract

Contract	Aggregate result across selection systems
Ceremonial revocability	Median social value 0.43; disaster 0.10; capture 0.84; legitimacy 0.25.
Irreversible tenure	Median social value 0.47; disaster 0.10; capture 0.86; legitimacy 0.38.
Plebiscitary hyper-revocation	Median social value 0.45; disaster 0.08; capture 0.63; legitimacy 0.29; timidity was much higher than under other contracts.
Real revocability with due process	Median social value 0.79; disaster 0.06; capture 0.48; legitimacy 0.56.

The result rejects two simplified claims. Merely declaring an office revocable does little when the incumbent controls the evidence and removal remains ceremonial. Making removal constantly easy reduces some disaster and capture but creates false removal, timidity, short horizons, and low legitimacy. Real revocability performs better in the model because removal is connected to independent verification and due process.

G.6 Results by Selection and Contract

The strongest cell was audited service under real revocability with due process, with median social value around 1.23 and low modeled disaster. Closed examination under the same contract reached approximately 0.98. Qualified lottery reached approximately 0.86. Hereditary succession improved substantially under the strong contract but remained more exposed to inherited capture. Popularity remained weak even after the contract reduced some of its damage.

The comparison does not show that examination is morally superior to election or that qualified lottery should appoint every elite. It shows that the contract can rescue some selection defects and that no contract fully repairs a selector dominated by theatre, wealth, or inherited advantage.

G.7 The Disaster Clause

The model operationalizes the book's central postulate through verified misconduct and contract cancellation. A privilege claim can be withdrawn when concealment or extraction is independently detected and connected to a material consequence. This is not ordinary punishment for failure. Good-faith error enters a different pathway and may produce a false-removal cost when institutions react badly.

A real legal implementation would require a much richer test. It would need to identify the officeholder's duty, the evidence available at the time, the quality of warnings, the degree of uncertainty, conflicts of interest, the causal contribution, the attempt to preserve or destroy records, the distribution of benefit, the proportionality of restitution, and rights of defence and appeal. The simulation compresses all of this into normalized variables.

The clause is also vulnerable to political capture. A new coalition may classify every inherited policy as reckless. A leader may avoid difficult decisions because any visible harm can later be called disaster. Opponents may manufacture evidence. Independent reviewers can become an unaccountable elite. Due process, a prospective definition of duty, and separation between investigation, judgment, and benefit are therefore part of the contract rather than optional protections for powerful people.

G.8 Limits

Candidate traits are static within a contest. Office itself can corrupt, educate, exhaust, or radicalize the person. Coalitions and organizations, rather than isolated candidates, usually govern. The model does not include parties, media systems, military loyalty, bureaucracy, legal culture, or the possibility that a highly aggressive leader is useful during an existential war.

The social-value weights are contestable. A security-first index could reward coordination and aggressive action more strongly. A libertarian index could penalize public authority itself. A pronatalist index might reward intergenerational continuity. The supplied data allow alternative aggregation.

The conditional conclusion is not that the simulation found good rulers. It suggests that selection should rely less on self-presentation, that evidence should be longitudinal and domain-specific, that qualified chance can reduce false precision, and that a credible contract of office may matter

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

more than the final refinement of a test. The objective is not to identify a superior human essence. It is to make destructive adaptation less rewarding after any human essence enters power.

APPENDIX H

Experiment Seven: Demography, Cultural Retention, and Ethical Leadership

H.1 Question

The experiment asks whether cultures that reproduce and retain members more effectively necessarily produce more corrigible leadership, and whether high-human-capital low-fertility cultures can preserve influence through technology and institutions. It was built to keep population, capability, power, and ethical leadership separate.

The full run uses 55,000 draws across eight generations. The horizon is deliberately long enough to expose compounding and too long to support literal forecasting. Fertility, conversion, retention, migration, family support, policy, and identity can change radically within one generation.

H.2 Cultural Ideal Types

Cultural type	Constructed profile
Hierarchical pronatalist	Desired fertility 3.5, high family support and retention, strong institutions, high hierarchy, moderate human-capital investment, and low leadership corrigibility.
Missionary institutional	Desired fertility 2.8, strong retention and attraction, very strong institutional depth, moderate hierarchy, and intermediate corrigibility.
Individualist innovation	Desired fertility 1.7, weak family support and retention, high autonomy, innovation, and human capital, and relatively high corrigibility.
Revocable civic	Desired fertility 2.25, substantial family support and institutions, high autonomy, innovation, and human capital, with the highest corrigibility baseline.
Viral opportunist	Desired fertility 2.1, low retention and institutional depth, high attraction and virality, moderate hierarchy, and low corrigibility.

These types do not correspond to named religions or populations. They are bundles constructed to expose different demographic and institutional strategies.

H.3 Futures

Future	Main change
Constraint and insecurity	Low security and care support, moderate pluralism, substantial state alliance, and power more dependent on population scale.
Distributed abundance	Strong security and care automation, high pluralism, weaker state alliance, and power more dependent on human capital and technology.
Oligarchic AI	Moderate security, strong state alliance and virality, low pluralism, and very high returns to technological capability.
Plural verification	Strong pluralism, substantial care and security, low state alliance, and a mixed population-technology power function.

H.4 Equations

Realized fertility begins with desired fertility and is reduced by economic, housing, and partnership barriers. Family support and care technology offset some of those barriers:

$$\text{realized_fertility} = \text{desired_fertility} - \text{economic_barrier} - \text{housing_barrier} - \text{partner_barrier} + \text{family_support} \times \text{care}$$

Births are normalized against a replacement benchmark of 2.1:

$$\text{births} = \text{population} \times \text{realized_fertility} \div 2.1$$

Retention determines the share of descendants remaining in the culture. Nonretained descendants, adult switchers, and migration are distributed by attraction. Attraction depends on baseline appeal, institutional depth, AI virality, pluralism, autonomy, state alliance, and hierarchy.

Human capital is updated through cultural investment, innovation, education return, resources per child, state capacity, and care automation. The model contains a quantity-quality relation: larger realized fertility can reduce resources per child under constraint, while abundance softens but does not abolish the relation.

Power is multiplicative:

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

$$\text{power} = \text{population} \wedge \text{population_weight} \times \text{human_capital} \wedge \text{technology_weight} \times \text{institution} \times \text{state_network_advantage}$$

Leadership corrigibility is separate. It begins with the cultural baseline, rises with pluralism, and falls when high hierarchy combines with state alliance.

H.5 Results

Future	Main full-run pattern
Constraint and insecurity	Hierarchical pronatalism reached a median population share of about 0.63 and an indicative power share of 0.44, while leadership corrigibility remained around 0.15. Revocable civic culture remained near 0.08 of population and 0.16 of power, with corrigibility around 0.65.
Distributed abundance	Hierarchical pronatalism remained the largest population at about 0.59 but held about 0.22 of indicative power. Revocable civic culture reached about 0.10 of population and 0.26 of power, with corrigibility around 0.78. Individualist innovation gained substantial power per person.
Oligarchic AI	Hierarchical pronatalism reached about 0.63 of population but only about 0.21 of power. Revocable civic culture held about 0.08 of population and 0.26 of power. Low pluralism reduced corrigibility across all types.
Plural verification	Hierarchical pronatalism remained largest at about 0.58. Revocable civic culture reached about 0.10 of population, 0.24 of power, and the highest corrigibility at about 0.83.

The model mechanically rewards higher fertility and retention with greater population share. This is not an independent discovery. Its useful contribution is the refusal to turn that growth into a moral score. A culture can reproduce effectively while selecting rigid leaders. Another can possess high leadership corrigibility and still become demographically marginal.

The result is compatible with demographic research showing that global religious composition is shaped by fertility, age structure, retention, conversion, migration, and mortality rather than conversion alone [PEW-RELIGIOUS-CHANGE-2025]. It also aligns with the broader warning

that global population projections hide large regional and cultural divergence [UN-WPP-2024].

H.6 Interpretation and Limits

Fertility is an unstable long-horizon parameter: development, education, housing, partnership, health, policy, migration, culture, and expectations can change within a generation. The model holds cultural bundles too stable. Real people intermarry and combine identities; a revocable civic ethic could live within several religions rather than compete as a separate population.

The model compresses gender and power. Housing, care, health, security, time, and family-friendly work can support reproduction; legal restriction, dependence, status pressure, forced marriage, and treating women or children as group assets can coerce it. Similar population outcomes may have opposite moral meanings.

The experiment does not model the gap between desired and realized fertility. Many people face economic, relational, health, and social barriers to the family life they want [UNFPA-2025]. Removing them supports reproductive autonomy; demographic targets for a state, religion, or elite do not.

The power function is contestable. Population supports mass mobilization but matters less when technology, capital, organization, location, and infrastructure dominate. Size creates markets and political weight while also straining resources and institutions.

Demography must be discussed without turning persons into instruments. Cultures that neither reproduce nor attract and retain members will shape less of the future, but reproductive success does not justify rigid leadership. A post-AI order should support desired family life and plural belonging without treating demographic victory as moral proof.

APPENDIX I

Robustness, Counterarguments, and Interpretive Limits

I.1 The Models Partly Favor the Thesis

The simulations were designed to examine whether truth-preserving, corrigible, mobile institutions can remain viable after paying costs for consultation, exposure, audit, and correction. It would be misleading to describe them as neutral competitions among political philosophies.

Open revocable orders receive stronger audit, voice, mobility, fairness, and reform capacity. Constitutional swarms receive strong rights, portability, and externality management. Audited service is scored through traits later rewarded in social value. Constitutional compression receives an effective evidentiary backend. Revocable civic culture begins with high corrigibility. These assumptions express the book's normative hypothesis.

The experiments test whether the hypothesis collapses after adding counter-costs. Revocable systems pay participation, coordination, exposure, false-removal, and timidity costs. Fragmented systems pay transaction and externality costs. High-cohesion systems receive coordination and provision advantages. Personalized theatre receives strong persuasive efficiency. Hereditary preparation can improve competence. High-fertility cultures accumulate population. The models permit humane orders to lose individual dimensions even when they perform well on the selected composite.

A different value system can produce a different ranking. A security-first model may place greater value on uniform command and lower value on voice. A libertarian model may penalize public authority and redistribution more strongly. A pronatalist model may treat population growth as a primary good. A consequentialist model may tolerate greater manipulation if it produces high welfare. A deontological model may reject some trade-offs regardless of measured stability.

The book's normative position is explicit: material capability, truth quality, dignity, reversible authority, and avoidance of concealed unilateral irreversible sacrifice are treated as civilizational goods. Output, survival, compliance, and population growth are not treated as sufficient measures.

I.2 Composite Indices Can Hide Moral Conflict

Welfare, legitimacy, deep stability, social value, capture, humiliation, and leadership corrigibility are constructed indices. Their weights are not natural constants. A high average can hide a small group bearing catastrophic harm. An institution can score well because many moderate

benefits outweigh one rights violation that a constitutional order should never aggregate away.

For that reason, the data files preserve major components. The main text emphasizes mechanisms rather than final scores. The charts should be read as comparative illustrations. They do not create an empirical unit in which dignity, violence, trust, energy, and authority become perfectly commensurable.

The problem is especially serious in the elite contract. Disaster probability is a normalized output, not the probability of a real catastrophe. Contract cancellation is a model response, not a legal doctrine. “Integrity” and “theatre” are latent synthetic traits, not psychometric measures. The model cannot distinguish a charismatic communicator using persuasion responsibly from a manipulator using the same skill to conceal extraction except through the other assigned variables.

I.3 History Contains External Power

The models are mostly closed systems. Real elites can preserve apparent stability by exporting cost. Empires obtain tribute, firms externalize pollution, states rely on foreign security guarantees, reserve currencies shift adjustment burdens, wealthy populations import material and care labor, and coercive orders receive geopolitical subsidy. A regime can remain internally quiet because someone else bears the resource, ecological, or violent liability.

The surveillance experiment contains a simplified geopolitical subsidy and external sanctuary. It does not model conquest, colonial extraction, international finance, migration restrictions, sanctions, war, or the use of an external enemy to maintain legitimacy. These mechanisms can extend dystopian survival far beyond the simulated pathways.

The resource experiment also treats the world as one aggregate. It cannot show how high-income consumption is supported by uneven extraction, trade, environmental burden, and bargaining power. Research on global resource use shows both large inequalities and a continued rise in extraction, while high-income populations consume far more materials and generate far greater climate impacts per person [UNEP-GRO-2024]. The model’s planetary benchmark compresses those relations.

I.4 Institutions Change the People Being Modeled

Human systems are reflexive. Once people know a selection criterion, they train for it. Once a metric controls funding, organizations game it. Once a surveillance system predicts dissent, dissent changes form. Once status rotation is institutionalized, ambitious people choose different careers. Once AI civic assistants become common, political language adapts to the assistants.

The simulations represent some adaptation through theatre amplification, inherited advantage, capture, and message personalization. They do not contain open-ended institutional evolution. A successful revocation mechanism would create new legal professions, insurance structures, reputation markets, and political strategies. Audited service could become a theatre of carefully selected service. Qualified lotteries could produce a class specialized in crossing eligibility thresholds. Constitutional metacults could become gatekeepers.

This is a core Outfinitist limit. Every successful boundary rule changes the environment and can move the boundary [ALBOAIE-OUTFINITISM-2026]. The proper response is periodic red-teaming, versioning, plural audit, and the ability to fork the institution, not the claim that one design has ended politics.

I.5 Stability Is Not One Outcome

The surveillance experiment separates survival, quiet order, trust, truth, hidden liability, and capacity. That separation reflects a philosophical choice. A ruler may care mainly about survival. A population may prefer quiet provision to participatory conflict. A security institution may define stability as the absence of attacks. An economist may emphasize investment and output. A constitutionalist may emphasize rights and peaceful correction.

No single index settles the dispute. The book treats deep stability as more valuable because it reduces the probability that visible order depends on censored information and accumulated liability. A durable dystopia is still durable. The label identifies a moral and epistemic deficit, not a computational inability to persist.

The same distinction applies to prosperity. Managed plenty can provide high material security. The model does not erase that achievement because the order is closed. It asks whether security purchased through permanent infantilization and unappealable surveillance is a sufficient social contract.

I.6 Resources Can Improve More Than the Model Assumes

The planetary experiment may be too pessimistic about technological substitution, clean-energy scale, circular manufacturing, precision agriculture, desalination, synthetic materials, and robotics. Some current scarcities may fall much faster than expected. New energy sources could expand the regenerative budget. AI may accelerate materials science and infrastructure design.

It may also be too optimistic. Efficiency improvements require infrastructure, minerals, grids, maintenance, and political coordination. Rebound can expand total demand. Data-centre electricity demand is

already rising rapidly, and critical-mineral refining remains highly concentrated [IEA-ENERGY-AI-2026; IEA-CRITICAL-2025]. Ecological systems are not perfectly substitutable. A technology that solves carbon may intensify land, water, mineral, biodiversity, or governance constraints.

The honest conclusion is not that technology cannot solve resource problems. It is that a capability improvement does not itself specify scale, distribution, total throughput, or the next bottleneck.

I.7 Demography Is Especially Uncertain

Eight generations make compounding visible and forecasting implausible. Fertility can change sharply within one generation. Retention can collapse after scandal or rise after conflict. Migration, intermarriage, education, policy, technology, and religious reform alter cultural composition. The ideal types are too stable and too exclusive.

The demographic experiment should not be used to rank living religions, ethnicities, nations, or genders. Its “leadership corrigibility” values are assigned analytical variables, not empirical moral scores. The result that high fertility increases population share is arithmetic. The relation between reproduction, consent, welfare, and ethical leadership remains political and historical.

I.8 AI Authorship Has Its Own Incentive Problem

The AI collaborator does not possess the human incentives criticized in the book, but it is not outside incentives. Its output is shaped by training data, prompts, selection, reward systems, tool access, and the institutional context in which it is used. It can produce severe honesty as a style. It can flatter the author’s philosophy by integrating it elegantly. It can mistake coherence for truth and generate a simulation whose assumptions already contain the desired conclusion.

The research process attempted to reduce this risk by making postulates explicit, constructing adversarial regimes, preserving code and data, separating main-text interpretation from formulas, and stating where results follow mechanically from parameter design. These measures improve inspectability. They do not make the collaboration neutral.

The reader should therefore apply the book’s own rule to the book. Ask which frame selected the problem, which values entered the indices, which evidence was omitted, which conclusions would change under another scale or horizon, and who benefits if the proposed vocabulary becomes influential.

I.9 What Would Falsify the Direction

The direction would be weakened if closed, highly concentrated orders consistently produced high trust, accurate information, effective correction,

broad capability, low hidden liability, and peaceful succession without relying on exported costs or coercive preference falsification. It would be weakened if real revocation systematically selected timid short-term leaders despite due process, while durable tenure reliably produced honest long-horizon stewardship. It would be weakened if polycentric mobility consistently increased capture and conflict more than it reduced permanent loser classes. It would be weakened if material abundance reliably dissolved status domination and political grievance without redistributing authority.

No single historical case settles these questions. The relevant evidence would compare institutions across time, include negative externalities, preserve the experience of losing groups, and distinguish visible compliance from private belief. Future work should calibrate narrower models to historical and organizational data rather than expanding one synthetic model into a theory of civilization.

The book's central proposition is therefore a research direction: elite power should be evaluated as a conditional social contract whose legitimacy depends on bounded service, independent information, reversible jurisdiction, and the ability to repair before disaster becomes the final correction. The simulations make that proposition more precise. They do not make it true by calculation.

REFERENCES

The citation keys used in the text are retained to make the evidentiary path easy to inspect. Web addresses were checked during preparation in July 2026.

Key	Reference
ALBOAIE-METACULT-2026	Alboaie, Sinică. <i>Metacult: Modernizing Humanity's Oldest Social Technology - How to Build Collective Power Without Crushing the Individual</i> . 2026 edition.
ALBOAIE-OUTFINITISM-2026	Alboaie, Sinică. <i>Outfinitism: Meta-Rationality and the Limits of Every Frame - Toward a Meta-Science of Limits</i> . 2026.
ALMAS-ET-AL-2025	Almås, Ingvild, Alexander W. Cappelen, Erik Ø. Sørensen, and Bertil Tungodden. "Fairness Across the World." Norwegian School of Economics Discussion Paper Series 6/2025. https://www.nhh.no/en/research-centres/fair/publications/2025/fairness-across-the-world/
BOWLER-DONOVAN-HAPP-1992	Bowler, Shaun, Todd Donovan, and Trudi Happ. "Ballot Propositions and Information Costs: Direct Democracy and the Fatigued Voter." <i>Western Political Quarterly</i> 45 (1992): 559-568.
DIKOTTER-2013	Dikötter, Frank. <i>The Tragedy of Liberation: A History of the Chinese Revolution, 1945-1957</i> . Bloomsbury Press, 2013.
FITZPATRICK-2017	Fitzpatrick, Sheila. <i>The Russian Revolution</i> . 4th ed. Oxford University Press, 2017.
GEORGESCU-2023	Georgescu, Oana Maria. "The Structural-Demographic Theory Revisited: An Empirical Test for Industrialized Societies." <i>PLOS ONE</i> 18, no. 11 (2023): e0287912. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0287912 .
GFN-EARTHS	Global Footprint Network. "How Many Earths? How Many Countries?" National Footprint and Biocapacity Accounts. https://overshoot.footprintnetwork.org/how-many-earths-or-countries-do-we-need/
HAGER-KRAKOWSKI-2022	Hager, Anselm, and Krzysztof Krakowski. "Does State Repression Spark Protests? Evidence from Secret Police Surveillance in Communist Poland." <i>American Political Science Review</i> 116, no. 2 (2022): 564-579. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055421000770 .
IEA-CRITICAL-2025	International Energy Agency. <i>Global Critical Minerals Outlook 2025</i> . Paris: IEA, 2025. https://www.iea.org/reports/global-critical-minerals-outlook-2025 .

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

Key	Reference
IASR-2026	Bengio, Yoshua, et al. <i>International AI Safety Report 2026</i> . London: UK Department for Science, Innovation and Technology, 2026. DSIT 2026/001; arXiv:2602.21012. https://internationalaisafetyreport.org/ .
IEA-ENERGY-AI-2026	International Energy Agency. <i>Key Questions on Energy and AI</i> . Updated 2026. https://www.iea.org/reports/key-questions-on-energy-and-ai .
IMF-AI-INEQUALITY-2025	Rockall, Emma, Marina M. Tavares, and Carlo Pizzinelli. "AI Adoption and Inequality." IMF Working Paper 25/68. Washington, DC: International Monetary Fund, 2025. https://www.imf.org/en/Publications/WP/Issues/2025/04/11/AI-Adoption-and-Inequality-565630 .
IPCC-2023	Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change. <i>Climate Change 2023: Synthesis Report</i> . Contribution of Working Groups I, II, and III to the Sixth Assessment Report. Geneva: IPCC, 2023. https://www.ipcc.ch/report/ar6/syr/ .
KIKSTRA-2021	Kikstra, Jarmo S., Alessio Mastrucci, Jihoon Min, Keywan Riahi, and Narasimha D. Rao. "Decent Living Gaps and Energy Needs Around the World." <i>Environmental Research Letters</i> 16, no. 9 (2021): 095006. https://doi.org/10.1088/1748-9326/ac1c27 .
LAU-REDLAWSK-2001	Lau, Richard R., and David P. Redlawsk. "Advantages and Disadvantages of Cognitive Heuristics in Political Decision Making." <i>American Journal of Political Science</i> 45, no. 4 (2001): 951-971. https://doi.org/10.2307/2669334 .
LICHTER-LOEFFLER-SIEGLOCH-2021	Lichter, Andreas, Max Löffler, and Sebastian Sieglöckh. "The Long-Term Costs of Government Surveillance: Insights from Stasi Spying in East Germany." <i>Journal of the European Economic Association</i> 19, no. 2 (2021): 741-789. https://doi.org/10.1093/jeaa/jvaa009 .
LUPIA-1994	Lupia, Arthur. "Shortcuts versus Encyclopedias: Information and Voting Behavior in California Insurance Reform Elections." <i>American Political Science Review</i> 88, no. 1 (1994): 63-76. https://doi.org/10.2307/2944882 .
MADSEN-DE-SILVA-2024	Madsen, Anastasia, and Shermin de Silva. "Societies with Fission-Fusion Dynamics as Complex Adaptive Systems: The Importance of Scale." <i>Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society B</i> 379 (2024): 20230175. https://doi.org/10.1098/rstb.2023.0175 .

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

Key	Reference
MATZ-2024	Matz, Sandra C., Jake Teeny, Sandrine L. Vaid, Harang Ju, and Gabriella M. Harari. "The Potential of Generative AI for Personalized Persuasion at Scale." <i>Scientific Reports</i> 14 (2024): 4692. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-024-53755-0 .
MCGINNIS-2011	McGinnis, Michael D. "An Introduction to IAD and the Language of the Ostrom Workshop: A Simple Guide to a Complex Framework." <i>Policy Studies Journal</i> 39, no. 1 (2011): 169-183. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1541-0072.2010.00401.x .
MILLWARD-HOPKINS-2020	Millward-Hopkins, Joel, Julia K. Steinberger, Narasimha D. Rao, and Yannick Oswald. "Providing Decent Living with Minimum Energy: A Global Scenario." <i>Global Environmental Change</i> 65 (2020): 102168. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.gloenvcha.2020.102168 .
MILLWARD-HOPKINS-2022	Millward-Hopkins, Joel. "Inequality Can Double the Energy Required to Secure Universal Decent Living." <i>Nature Communications</i> 13 (2022): 5028. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41467-022-32729-8 .
NORTH-WALLIS-WEINGAST-2009	North, Douglass C., John Joseph Wallis, and Barry R. Weingast. <i>Violence and Social Orders: A Conceptual Framework for Interpreting Recorded Human History</i> . Cambridge University Press, 2009.
OSTROM-2010	Ostrom, Elinor. "Beyond Markets and States: Polycentric Governance of Complex Economic Systems." <i>American Economic Review</i> 100, no. 3 (2010): 641-672. https://doi.org/10.1257/aer.100.3.641 .
PEW-RELIGIOUS-CHANGE-2025	Pew Research Center. "How the Global Religious Landscape Changed from 2010 to 2020." June 9, 2025. https://www.pewresearch.org/religion/2025/06/09/how-the-global-religious-landscape-changed-from-2010-to-2020/ .
SALVI-2025	Salvi, Francesco, et al. "On the Conversational Persuasiveness of GPT-4." <i>Nature Human Behaviour</i> 9 (2025): 1645-1653. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-025-02194-6 .
SIMON-1955	Simon, Herbert A. "A Behavioral Model of Rational Choice." <i>Quarterly Journal of Economics</i> 69, no. 1 (1955): 99-118. https://doi.org/10.2307/1884852 .

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

Key	Reference
SMITH-ET-AL-2012	Smith, Heather J., Thomas F. Pettigrew, Gina M. Pippin, and Silvana Bialosiewicz. "Relative Deprivation: A Theoretical and Meta-Analytic Review." <i>Personality and Social Psychology Review</i> 16, no. 3 (2012): 203-232. https://doi.org/10.1177/1088868311430825 .
STANFORD-AI-INDEX-2026	Stanford Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence. <i>AI Index Report 2026</i> . Stanford University, 2026. https://hai.stanford.edu/ai-index/2026-ai-index-report .
TURCHIN-2013	Turchin, Peter. "Modeling Social Pressures Toward Political Instability." <i>Cliodynamics</i> 4, no. 2 (2013): 241-280. https://doi.org/10.21237/C7clio4221333 .
TYLER-2006	Tyler, Tom R. "Psychological Perspectives on Legitimacy and Legitimation." <i>Annual Review of Psychology</i> 57 (2006): 375-400. https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.psych.57.1029.04.190038 .
UN-WPP-2024	United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs, Population Division. <i>World Population Prospects 2024: Summary of Results</i> . New York: United Nations, 2024. https://population.un.org/wpp/ .
UNDP-AI-DIVERGENCE-2025	United Nations Development Programme, Regional Bureau for Asia and the Pacific. <i>The Next Great Divergence: Why AI May Widen Inequality Between Countries</i> . 2025. https://www.undp.org/asia-pacific/publications/next-great-divergence-why-ai-may-widen-inequality-between-countries .
UNEP-GRO-2024	United Nations Environment Programme, International Resource Panel. <i>Global Resources Outlook 2024: Bend the Trend - Pathways to a Liveable Planet as Resource Use Spikes</i> . Nairobi: UNEP, 2024. https://www.resourcepanel.org/reports/global-resources-outlook-2024 .
UNFPA-2025	United Nations Population Fund. <i>The Real Fertility Crisis: The Pursuit of Reproductive Agency in a Changing World</i> . State of World Population 2025. New York: UNFPA, 2025. https://www.unfpa.org/swp2025 .
VIOLA-2007	Viola, Lynne. <i>The Unknown Gulag: The Lost World of Stalin's Special Settlements</i> . Oxford University Press, 2007.

REVOCABLE NOBILITY

Key	Reference
VAN-TILBURG-IGOU-2016	Van Tilburg, Wijnand A. P., and Eric R. Igou. "Going to Political Extremes in Response to Boredom." <i>European Journal of Social Psychology</i> 46 (2016): 687-699. https://doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.2205 .
XU-2021	Xu, Xu. "To Repress or to Co-opt? Authoritarian Control in the Age of Digital Surveillance." <i>American Journal of Political Science</i> 65, no. 2 (2021): 309-325. https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12514 .